

THE FORGOTTEN SEVEN



MAHAD A. BAJWA

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CHAPTER ONE

THE BINDERY

The radio in the kitchen was already going when Owen came down the stairs.

“...and the new Light Grandmaster was back at Harbor Arena last night, folks, for her very first exhibition. Sixteen years old and five months on the job, and I don’t mind telling you, when Talia Reyes lit up that arena I had to take my hat off to shade my eyes. And afterward, when we asked her who that one was for, she looked right into the microphone and said, ‘*Cable Street.*’ How about that...”

“Turn it up!” Tess said.

Owen reached over and turned it off.

“Hey!”

“I’m eating.”

His sister glared at him. She was ten, sitting cross-legged on a kitchen chair with her trading cards spread over the table in neat rows, like she was running a bank. The seven Grandmasters had the middle of the table to themselves. The newest card sat right in the center, still shiny, with no bent corners at all. It showed a girl with her dark hair tied back in a high ponytail and her hand raised, light pouring off her fingers. Across the bottom, in gold letters: TALIA REYES, LIGHT GRANDMASTER.

And under that, in blue ink and slightly smudged, in handwriting Owen had been reading off notes passed in class since they were seven: *To Tess, my number one fan. Don’t trade me. —T.*

It had come in the post two months ago, in a stiff Ministry envelope with Tess’s name on the front. There had been nothing in it for Owen. There had never been anything for Owen.

“I’m never trading her,” Tess said, as though he had suggested it. “Not even for Rourke.”

“Nobody asked you to trade her.”

“People ask me *every day*.”

Pop was at the stove with his sleeves rolled up and his work shirt already buttoned for the early shift at the Eastside power station. He snapped his fingers over the burner, and a flame the size of a match flicked to life and caught the gas. It was the same small, tidy flame he’d made every morning of Owen’s life, the same one he fed into the boilers at the station eight hours a day, six days a week. His griamore sat on the windowsill with its cloth cover faded from red to a tired pink. It was thin. Most people’s were.

“There he is,” Pop said. “Sixteen. How’s it feel?”

“Same as fifteen.”

“Give it till lunch.” Pop slid a plate across the table: one fried egg and a bun with a candle stuck in it. “Your mother left that before her shift. Says happy birthday, says don’t be a smart mouth at the Bindery, says wear the good shirt.”

“I’m wearing the good shirt.”

Pop looked at the shirt. “That’s the good shirt?”

“It’s the one without the hole.”

Tess was still watching him over her cards. “Do you think Talia will come? To the Bindery? For your day?”

“Why would she?”

It came out flat and hard, and the kitchen went quiet. Tess blinked at him. Pop glanced over from the stove and didn’t say anything, which was worse.

Owen looked down at his egg.

“Light the candle,” Tess said after a moment, quieter. “You have to make a wish. Everyone makes a wish on Bindery day. Talia made a wish.”

Owen knew. He’d been sitting right there when she made it.

Five months ago, in this same kitchen, on Talia’s sixteenth birthday, she’d sat in the chair where Owen was sitting now, and Pop had lit a candle in a bun for her too, because her own dad worked nights and somebody had to. She’d squeezed her eyes shut and wished so hard her nose wrinkled. Afterward Owen had asked what she’d wished for, and she’d grabbed his wrist under the table and whispered it, like it was a secret between the two

of them.

Something that gets us out of here.

Us, she'd said. Not me.

Then she'd gone up the hill to the Bindery and come back the Light Grandmaster, and it turned out the wish only had room for one.

Pop reached over and snapped his fingers above the bun. The candle caught.

Owen looked at it. Everybody knew the odds. Seven Grandmaster books in the whole world, and a Grandmaster book only came free when its holder died. The old Light Grandmaster had passed away last winter, at ninety-one, in his sleep. For three months after that, every sixteen-year-old in the country had gone to the Bindery holding their breath. Then one Tuesday in the spring, a girl from Cable Street had put her hand on a blank book, and that had been that.

And now it was happening all over again. Six weeks ago, the Thunder Grandmaster, a gruff old man named Barnaby Holt, had died in his armchair during a rainstorm, which the papers all agreed was very fitting. His book was sitting blank somewhere up the hill, waiting, and every sixteen-year-old in the country was holding their breath again.

But you didn't wish for Grandmaster. You wished for something good and steady, the kind of book people could build a life on: fire for the power station, water for the canals and the fire brigade, earth for the construction crews. Or one of the hundred other kinds of books people got every day. Strength for the docks. Healing for the hospital. Sound, if you wanted to work in radio. Metal, if you wanted to work anywhere at all, because the foundries were always hiring.

What Owen wanted was harder to say out loud, even inside his own head. He didn't need Grandmaster. He just wanted something that was *his*. Something nobody could look straight through.

He blew out the candle and didn't say what he'd wished for.

"Did you wish for Thunder?" Tess demanded. "You wished for Thunder. Everyone's wishing for Thunder. You can't get it, though. Talia already got Light, and Pop says lightning doesn't strike the same street twice."

"I said that one time," said Pop.

"You said it at *dinner*."

"Eat your breakfast, Tess."

"I already ate my breakfast. I'm doing inventory."

Owen picked up his plate and took it to the sink. On his way past, Pop put a heavy hand on his shoulder and left it there a second.

"Whatever you get," Pop said, "you come straight home after and show us. You hear? Straight home."

"I hear."

"Good lad."

* * *

Owen took the tram up the hill by himself.

He swung up onto the back rail without paying, like always, and stood with the wind in his face while Port Aldren rolled past: the fish markets and the cannery smokestacks, the big cranes at the harbor where the earth crews and the strength crews lifted cargo off freighters by hand, the laundry lines strung between tenements. Farther up, the city climbed the hill. The buildings got taller and cleaner there, with electric signs in the windows and motorcars shining at the curbs. At the very top, the Ministry's white towers stood with a government airship moored at the mast, its silver belly catching the morning sun.

Talia lived up there now. Somewhere in those towers she had rooms of her own, and a trainer, and a handler, and a schedule written out by the hour.

Owen didn't know which window was hers, and he told himself he didn't care.

At the corner of Market Street, the tram passed a warehouse with a poster on the side of it twenty feet tall. It was Talia, the same picture as on Tess's card: hand raised, light pouring off her fingers, her face calm and serious in a way Owen had never once seen it look in real life. Under her, in huge letters: THE LIGHT OF PORT ALDREN.

Somebody had drawn a mustache on her.

Owen looked away. He'd done it in the second month, with a stick of harbor chalk, climbing the fire escape in the dark. He'd felt good about it for about a minute. Then he'd felt stupid, and then he'd felt worse, and the rain hadn't washed it off the way he'd been counting on.

He leaned his head against the tram's cold brass pole and let himself remember the whole thing, all the way through, the way he'd been trying not to for five months. It was his birthday. He figured he was allowed.

* * *

He'd skipped school to go up to the Bindery with her that day.

She'd been so nervous she'd held on to his sleeve the whole time they waited in line, and when the clerk called her name she'd let go of it one finger at a time. She'd put her hand on the cover, and for a second nothing had happened. Then the gold Light mark on the ceiling, eighty feet up, had started to *glow*, and a clean white light had poured down out of it and filled the whole hall, every corner, so bright that for a moment there were no shadows anywhere.

Everybody in the building had gone silent.

And then Talia had turned around, with light still pouring off her like water, and she'd found him in the crowd, and she'd *screamed*. Not scared. Happy. The kind of scream you do on the last day of school. She'd run straight through the velvet ropes and thrown herself at him so hard they'd both nearly gone over, and she'd been laughing and crying at the same time, her face pressed into his shoulder, saying, "*Owen, Owen, Owen, did you see, did you SEE,*" and he'd been laughing too, spinning her around in the middle of the Bindery with three hundred people staring, and he had never in his whole life been so happy for another person.

"*Us,*" she'd said into his ear. "*I told you. I told you, didn't I? Us.*"

Then the men in grey suits had come through the doors. They'd been polite about it. They'd said *Miss Reyes* and *congratulations* and *if you'd come with us, please*, and they'd walked her out to a black motorcar at the bottom of the steps. She'd leaned out of the back window as it pulled away and yelled back at him over the traffic: "*Tonight! Come over tonight! Bring cake!*"

So he had.

He'd taken every coin he'd saved from coiling rope on the docks that spring, and he'd gone down to Sorrell's bakery and bought the best cake in the window, the kind with real sugar icing, and he'd stood there while Mrs. Sorrell piped *TALIA* across the top in gold, because gold was the Light Grandmaster's color and he'd wanted it to be perfect. He'd carried it all the way back to Cable Street in both arms like it was made of glass.

There had been a black motorcar parked outside her building. There had been two men in grey suits standing by the front steps, and a third one on the landing, and the door of the Reyes flat had been open, with light spilling out of it.

Talia had been standing in the doorway.

She'd changed out of her school clothes. She was wearing something white that he'd never seen before, stiff and new, and her hair was pinned up, and there was a tall thin man in a grey suit standing at her shoulder with a wristwatch he kept looking at. Owen had come up the stairs with the cake, grinning, and said, "Tal! Look. Look what I..."

And she had looked at him.

She'd looked right at him, for one second, with an expression he'd never seen on her face before and couldn't name.

Then she'd looked away, as if he were nobody. As if he were a stranger who'd come up the wrong stairs. She'd turned to the man in the grey suit and said something too quiet to hear, and the man had nodded, and she had gone back inside, and the door of the Reyes flat had closed.

Just like that.

Owen had stood on the landing holding the cake. One of the men in grey had looked at him, and then at the cake, and then back at the door, and hadn't said anything at all. After a while Owen had gone back down the stairs. He'd sat on the front step in the dark for a long time, with the cake on his knees and *TALIA* written across it in gold, waiting for the door to open again.

It hadn't.

In the morning, the black motorcar was gone, and so was she. She'd moved up the hill that night. She hadn't said goodbye. She never wrote. She never visited. Not one letter in five months, not one word, though the tram

went up the hill every twenty minutes and she knew exactly which window on Cable Street was his, because she'd climbed through it about a thousand times.

Two months later, a signed card had come in the post for Tess.

Nothing for Owen.

He'd given the cake to the Delgado kids on the first floor. He hadn't been able to eat it. He hadn't been able to eat anything from Sorrell's since.

* * *

The tram ground its way up the hill, and the Bindery came into view.

It was the biggest building Owen had ever been inside. The whole place was white marble, cold and echoing, with brass rails that split the floor into long lines and a ceiling painted with the seven Grandmaster marks in gold leaf: flame, water, air, earth, light, ice, and thunder, so high up you had to lean back to see them. The Light mark had been freshly regilded this spring, and it shone brighter than the others. Under the Thunder mark, somebody had hung a long black ribbon for mourning, and it stirred a little in the draft from the doors. Big brass electric lamps hung on long chains from the ceiling, and a clock hung on the wall behind every clerk's desk, and all of them ticked together, so the whole hall had a slow, steady pulse to it.

The line was full of sixteen-year-olds and their mothers. Owen's mother was at the cannery and his father was at the station, because you didn't miss a shift for a Bindery day unless you could afford to, and the Calders couldn't. It didn't matter. Plenty of kids came alone. He found the end of the line and stood in it.

A sign at the front said HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE READY in letters two feet tall. A man with a mop was leaning against the wall by the door, looking bored. Along the walls, every twenty feet or so, stood a Bindery warden in a dark grey uniform with a brass whistle on a chain and a heavy leather case on his belt. Owen had never paid them much attention before. Nobody did. They were there for the rare kid whose first touch went wrong, the fire that went up too high or the water that wouldn't stop.

It went slowly. At the front of each line was a desk, at each desk was a clerk in a green visor, and in front of each clerk was a stack of blank books: plain grey cloth, all the same. You gave your name. You put your hand on a book. And then something happened.

Owen had been to watch before, and none of it surprised him. It was the same every year. A girl two lines over put her hand down and her book went hot and smoked a little, and a red mark inked itself onto the cover, and her whole family cheered, because fire was the power station. A tall boy got water, and his book soaked through and dripped on the marble, and the man with the mop sighed and went over to it. A heavyset kid got strength and accidentally lifted the front of the desk an inch off the floor, and the clerk said "*Put it down, please,*" without even looking up. A small girl got healing, and a boy right after her got sound and said "Oh!" so loud it rattled the windows, and then clapped both hands over his mouth, horrified, while everybody laughed.

Nobody made a fuss over any of it. A book was a book. A mark was a mark. It was a good day, and a normal one.

"*Next,*" called the clerk at the front of the line. The line shuffled forward. Owen shuffled with it.

Behind him, somebody gasped. Then somebody else did. Then the whole back half of the hall went quiet, and a murmur started at the doors and rolled forward like a wave: *it's her, it's her, that's the Light Grandmaster.*

Owen didn't turn around.

He didn't have to. He could hear her coming across the marble floor, fast, the way she'd always walked, like she was late for something. He could hear a man's heavier footsteps hurrying after her, and a man's voice saying, "Miss Reyes, *please,* the schedule." He could hear people shuffling back out of her way. And then he could feel it, the way you feel sun on the back of your neck, when she stopped right behind him.

"Owen," Talia said.

He looked straight ahead at the sign. HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE READY.

"Owen. Hey." Her voice was a little out of breath. "Happy birthday. I wasn't sure if you'd... I wanted to be here. For yours."

He didn't say anything. He didn't turn around.

For five months he'd had whole arguments with her in his head, on the roof, on the tram, in the dark before he fell asleep. He'd planned exactly what he'd say to her if she ever came back. He'd had speeches. He'd won every single one of those arguments.

And now she was right here, close enough that he could feel the strange warmth coming off her like a stove, and he found he didn't want any of the speeches. He only wanted one thing. He wanted her to know what it had felt like, standing on that landing with a cake in his arms, while a door closed.

So he looked straight ahead and said nothing at all.

The hall had gone very quiet around them. Everyone was staring. The Light Grandmaster, in her long white coat with the gold mark on the shoulder, standing in a Bindery line behind a skinny dock kid in a patched shirt, and the dock kid wouldn't even turn around.

"Owen," Talia said again, much quieter. "*Please*. I know. I know what I did. There's a reason, I swear there's a reason, I just can't..."

"Miss Reyes," said the man's voice behind her, low and urgent. Owen knew that voice. He'd heard it on a landing on Cable Street, five months ago. "Twenty minutes. The airfield. And people are *watching*."

"I *know*, Mr. Crane." A pause. Then, very quietly, to the back of Owen's head: "I'm going to stay until you're done. You don't have to talk to me. I'm just going to stay."

Owen stared at the sign until the letters stopped looking like words.

"*Next*," called the clerk.

It was Owen.

* * *

The clerk was a thin, tired man with a pencil behind his ear and a nameplate that said MR. PETTIBONE. He looked at Owen's certificate, looked at his ledger, wrote a number, and slid a blank book across the desk. Just grey cloth and blank pages, with a faint smell of dust and glue.

"Palm flat on the cover," Mr. Pettibone said. "Don't pull away, whatever it feels like."

Nobody was watching.

Owen realized it all at once. The whole hall was still staring at Talia: whispering, pointing, a girl two lines over trying to work up the nerve to ask for her autograph. Even Mr. Pettibone kept glancing past Owen's shoulder at the white coat. Owen was standing at the desk on his own Bindery day, the one day in your whole life when everybody is supposed to be watching you, and he was invisible. He was standing in her shadow, which was a funny thing to be able to do with somebody made of light.

Something hot and heavy went through his chest. He was ashamed of it, and it didn't go away. If anything, it got heavier.

He wiped his hand on his trousers. His heart was going hard.

He put his hand on the book.

* * *

The first thing he felt was nothing at all.

The book was cool and dry under his palm, just cloth, and for one long second nothing happened, and Owen had time to think, *Of course. Of course it's nothing. Of course it's me.*

Then the weight came.

It didn't come *to* him. It came *out* of him. It poured out of the book and up his arm and through his chest, and out, out in every direction at once, like a wave rolling out from a stone dropped in still water, except the wave was *heavy*, heavier than anything, heavy the way the bottom of the harbor is heavy, heavy the way the whole world is heavy when you're lying awake at three in the morning.

Mr. Pettibone went down first. He didn't fall. He was *pressed*, face-first onto his own ledger, as if a giant hand had come down on the back of his head. His visor cracked. His pencil shot off the desk and hit the marble so hard it snapped in half.

Then the whole line behind Owen went down.

It happened all at once, three hundred people, like a field of wheat under a sudden wind. Knees buckled. Mothers folded over their children. The heavyset kid who'd lifted the desk hit the floor on his hands and knees and then his elbows gave out and he went flat. The tall boy's wet book tore out

of his hands and slammed into the floor with a *crack*. People screamed, and then they couldn't scream, because they couldn't lift their chests to breathe enough to do it. All they could do was lie there, pinned, gasping, with their cheeks pressed against the cold white marble.

The brass rails bent. Owen watched them do it: long, polished brass rails sagging slowly toward the floor in the middle, groaning, like licorice left out in the sun. The chains of the great electric lamps snapped taut, and the lamps dropped two feet all at once and hung there, swinging and straining, the bulbs flaring and popping one after another in bursts of white glass. Along the far wall, the clocks tore loose from their hooks. They didn't fall so much as get *yanked* to the floor, all of them, one after another down the whole length of the hall, *smash smash smash smash*, until there was no ticking left at all.

The marble under the desk cracked. A thin black line ran out from Owen's feet, and then another, and then a whole ring of them, spreading slowly out through the white stone like frost across a window.

Dust sifted down from the ceiling in long grey curtains. High above, eighty feet up, the seven gold Grandmaster marks trembled on the plaster.

And Owen stood in the middle of it all, and he felt *light*.

That was the worst part. That was the part he would remember afterward, in the dark, for a long time. Everyone in the building was being crushed into the floor, and he felt lighter than he had in five months. Lighter than air. As if the weight he'd been carrying around since that night on the landing had finally, *finally* gone somewhere, and he never had to hold it again.

Then he looked down.

Nobody was standing. Nobody in the whole Bindery, not the clerks, not the wardens along the walls, not the man with the mop. Everyone was down, pressed flat, three hundred people lying on the marble with their faces turned toward him, and every single one of them was staring at him.

Everyone was watching him now.

The thought came, and it was so ugly that it frightened him more than anything else in the room.

He tried to take his hand off the book. It wouldn't come. It was the only thing in the building that wasn't heavy, and it was stuck to the cover like it had grown there.

"Owen."

He turned his head.

Talia was the only one moving. She was down like everyone else, but she was fighting it. She had one hand flat on the marble and the other pressed to her chest, and light was coming off her in waves, bright white-gold light, flaring and flickering like a lamp in a gale, pushing back against the weight. Her long white coat was spread out on the floor around her. Her jaw was clenched so hard he could see the muscle standing out. Slowly, shaking, inch by inch, she was pushing herself up onto one knee.

The Light Grandmaster, on her knees in the Bindery. On her knees in front of him.

"Owen," she said again, through her teeth. Her golden eyes were fixed on his face. She didn't look angry. She didn't look scared of him. She looked scared *for* him. *"Owen. Look at me. Let go. You have to let go."*

"I can't..."

"Yes, you can. It's yours. It listens to you. Just let go."

He looked at her. At her face, and her shaking arm, and the light pouring off her like it had poured off her five months ago in this same hall, when she'd run through the ropes and thrown her arms around him and said *us*.

Something in his chest let go before his hand did.

The weight *stopped*.

It didn't fade. It just stopped, all at once, the way a sound stops when you close a door. The lamps jerked back up on their chains and swung wildly, creaking. The dust hung in the air. The brass rails stayed bent. Three hundred people took one huge, ragged breath at the same time, and then the hall filled up with coughing and crying and a child somewhere wailing at the top of his lungs.

Owen's hand came off the book.

He looked down at it. A mark had inked itself onto the grey cloth while he wasn't looking, dark as a bruise, and it wasn't a flame or a wave or any of

the others from the ceiling. The book was thicker than it had been, and heavy, so heavy he could feel it pulling at the desk. Only the first page had filled. He could see a single word written at the top of it in dark ink, through the gap in the cover.

Gravity.

* * *

Nobody moved for a moment. Then everybody moved at once, scrambling back, away from the desk, away from him, dragging their children with them, bumping into each other in their hurry. A ring of empty cracked marble opened up around him. Nobody would come inside it.

Mr. Pettibone was sitting on the floor behind the desk with his broken visor in his hands, staring at Owen like he was a lit stick of dynamite.

And then, from somewhere across the hall, someone blew a whistle.

It was a long, sharp blast, and then another answered it from the far wall, and another from the doors, and suddenly the wardens were coming. They were dusty and bruised, some of them limping, but they were coming across the cracked marble from every side at once in their dark grey uniforms, and they'd opened the heavy leather cases on their belts. Owen saw what was in them. Cuffs. Thick, dull iron cuffs, with strange marks cut into them in rings, marks that weren't in any registry he'd ever seen.

"I didn't..." Owen took a step back and hit the desk. "I didn't *mean*... I didn't do anything, it just..."

The first warden reached him. Then two more. Nobody said anything to him. Nobody said his name. They took his arms, not roughly but not gently either, and turned him around and pushed him face-first against the desk, the same desk where Mr. Pettibone had been crushed flat a minute ago. Someone yanked his hands behind his back.

The iron closed around his wrists.

It was *cold*. Not normal cold, like metal. A deep, strange cold that went straight up his arms and into his chest and found the place where the weight had come from and pressed down on it, hard, until it went quiet. He felt his book go dead on the desk in front of him, like a light going out.

A warden picked up the book with a pair of heavy gloves, the way you'd pick up something that might bite, and dropped it into an iron box and shut the lid.

"Hey!" Owen twisted around. "That's *mine!* That's..."

"Walk," said the warden holding his arm.

"Where? Where are we..."

"Walk."

They walked him. Across the cracked marble, through the ring of people pressed back against the walls, past the bent brass rails and the smashed clocks and the swinging broken lamps. Everyone stared. Everyone. A mother pulled her daughter behind her skirt as he went by. A boy he'd been standing in line with an hour ago, the one who'd gotten sound, looked at him with his mouth open and didn't make a sound at all.

At the side of the hall, near the desks, an old woman with white hair and reading glasses on a chain was pulling herself up by a clerk's chair. She wasn't looking at Owen. She was looking at the iron box in the warden's arms, and her face had gone completely white.

"Stop!"

Talia.

She was on her feet. Owen didn't know how. Her white coat was grey with dust and her hair had come half out of its ribbon, and she was still shaking, but she was on her feet and she was running across the hall toward him, and the light was coming off her again, so bright that the wardens had to squint.

"Stop! Let him go! He didn't do anything, he didn't *mean* it, it was his first touch, it happens, it happens *twice a week*, you can't just..."

Mr. Crane caught her by the arm. Owen had never seen the man move fast before. He caught her and held on, even as her light flared hot enough to make him flinch.

"Miss Reyes. *Miss Reyes*. This is not your concern."

"*Not my...*" She wrenched against his grip. "*He's my...* Let go of me!"

"You cannot be seen with this," Mr. Crane said, low and very fast. "Do you understand me? Not now. Not with *this*. Not after everything we've..."

"*I don't care!*"

The wardens kept walking. The bronze doors were open ahead, full of bright morning sunlight, and at the bottom of the steps Owen could see a long black motorcar with its back door already standing open, waiting. He stumbled on the top step, and a warden's hand hauled him upright again.

He looked back.

He couldn't help it. He looked back over his shoulder through the doors, into the wrecked white hall, and she was right there. She was still fighting against Mr. Crane's grip, still reaching for him, her hand stretched out toward him across the cracked marble with light spilling off her fingers. And her face was the face he'd seen five months ago, on a landing on Cable Street, for one second before a door closed. He still couldn't name it.

But he was starting to think it might not have been what he'd thought.

"OWEN!" Talia screamed. Her voice cracked in half. "*Where are you taking him? WHERE ARE YOU TAKING HIM?*"

Nobody answered her.

The motorcar door slammed shut.

CHAPTER TWO

THE LOW OFFICE

The motorcar didn't go up the hill.

Owen had been sure it would. He'd been sitting in the back seat between two wardens with his hands locked behind him, watching the bronze doors of the Bindery shrink in the rear window, and he'd been sure that any second now the car would swing left onto Crown Avenue and start the long climb toward the white towers, the same way the black motorcar had carried Talia five months ago.

Instead it turned right. Then right again. It crept along the side of the Bindery, so close that Owen could have touched the marble if his hands had been free, and then it dipped down a ramp he had never noticed in sixteen years of walking past this building. A pair of iron gates opened at the bottom without anyone getting out to open them, and the car rolled through into the dark, and the gates closed behind it.

The headlamps showed a tunnel. Old brick, black with damp, curving away downhill.

Nobody in the car said anything. The warden on Owen's left had the iron box on his knees, both gloved hands flat on the lid, the way you'd hold down something that might try to get out. The warden on his right was looking straight ahead. Neither of them had looked at Owen once since the Bindery steps.

Owen's wrists ached. The cuffs were thick and dull and heavier than they looked, and the cold coming off them hadn't let up for a second. It sat in his arms like frozen water. It sat in his chest, in the place where the weight had come from, pressing down on it the way you'd press a hand over somebody's mouth.

"What are these?" His voice came out cracked. He cleared his throat and tried again. "The cuffs. What are they?"

The warden on his right didn't turn his head. "Binders."

“What do they do?”

“They bind.”

The car rolled on. The tunnel curved, and curved again, always down.

Owen leaned his head back against the leather seat and closed his eyes and tried to breathe slowly, the way Mom had taught him when he was small and couldn't sleep through a thunderstorm. In through the nose. Out through the mouth. It didn't help. Every time he closed his eyes he saw the hall. The brass rails bending. Mr. Pettibone's face pressed into his ledger. Three hundred people flat on the marble, and all of them looking at him.

And Talia.

On her knees. Light pouring off her. *Let go. It listens to you.*

Then Talia with Mr. Crane's hand on her arm, and her voice screaming *where are you taking him.*

He'd almost believed it. For about half a second, on the steps, looking back at her face, he'd almost let himself think it meant something. But he'd had a long, dark tunnel to think it over since then, and it didn't take long to come undone.

Mr. Crane was Ministry. Mr. Crane had stood at her shoulder on that landing five months ago while she shut the door in Owen's face. Mr. Crane had been at the Bindery this morning, checking his watch, and the moment it went wrong, there had been wardens with cuffs ready in their belt cases, as if they'd been expecting it. As if somebody had told them to expect it.

She'd said she'd stay until he was done.

She'd stayed, all right. She'd stayed right up until they put him in the car.

Something moved under the cold in his chest. Something hot. The Binders around his wrists went colder in answer, so cold it burned, and Owen hissed through his teeth and made himself stop thinking about her.

The warden on the left glanced down at the cuffs. Then, for the first time, at Owen's face. Then he looked away again, and his gloved hands pressed a little harder on the lid of the box.

* * *

The tunnel ended at a wall of iron.

Two more wardens were waiting there with lanterns. They opened the car door and pulled Owen out by the elbows, and the cold air hit him, wet and old, smelling of stone and rust and something underneath that he couldn't name. Something like the inside of a church that had been shut up for a hundred years.

There was a lift cage set into the iron wall. They put him in it, and three wardens got in after him, and the one with the box, and someone pulled the gate shut with a clang that went on echoing for a long time.

Then they went down.

Owen had ridden lifts before, in the big department store on Market Street where Mom took them once a year to look at the Christmas windows. This was nothing like that. The cage dropped through solid rock, lit only by the lantern swinging from the warden's hand, and it kept dropping, long past where it should have stopped. The walls went from brick to rough-cut stone to something older than that: huge smooth blocks fitted together without mortar, so tight you couldn't have slid a knife blade between them. Owen counted slowly in his head to keep from shaking. He got to ninety before the cage shuddered and stopped.

"How far down are we?"

No answer. They opened the gate and walked him out.

It was a corridor. Long and straight and low, with a line of caged electric bulbs down the middle of the ceiling that hummed and flickered. The floor was the same old smooth stone, worn into a shallow groove down the middle by more feet than Owen could imagine. Iron doors lined both walls, each one with a small slot at eye level and a number painted above it in faded white.

And on the walls between the doors, there were marks.

Or there had been. Someone had painted them there once, big and careful, one between every pair of doors, and then someone else had come along later with a chisel and scraped every single one of them off. All that was left were ghost shapes, pale gouged outlines in the stone where the paint had been, and deep angry scratches across the middle of each one.

Owen counted them as they walked. He couldn't help it.

Seven. Seven scraped-off shapes.

They stopped at a door with the number 4 above it. One warden unlocked it with a key the size of Owen's hand. Another pushed him inside.

"Wait," Owen said. "My book. That's my..."

The door shut.

He heard the key turn. He heard their footsteps going away down the corridor, and the lift gate clang, and the long mechanical groan of the cage going up, and up, and up, until he couldn't hear it anymore.

Then he couldn't hear anything at all.

* * *

The cell was small. Stone walls, stone floor, stone ceiling low enough that Owen could have touched it flat-handed if his hands had been free. A narrow iron cot bolted to the wall with a thin grey blanket folded on it. A bucket in the corner. A single electric bulb in a wire cage above the door, giving off a thin yellow light that didn't quite reach the corners.

That was all.

He stood in the middle of it for a long time, because he didn't know what else to do.

Then he sat down on the edge of the cot, awkwardly, with his hands still locked behind him, and stared at the iron door.

Whatever you get, you come straight home after and show us. Straight home.

Pop would be at the station now. He'd be shoveling coal into the boilers, snapping his little flame, thinking about what book his son had gotten. Mom would be at the cannery. Tess would be at school, telling everyone in her class that her brother was getting his grammar today, and making them all guess what it would be.

They'd come home at six. They'd sit down at the kitchen table with the bun from breakfast still on the counter. And they'd wait.

And Owen wouldn't come.

Would anybody tell them? Would a man in a grey suit knock on the door on Cable Street and take his hat off and say *there's been an accident*? Or would nobody come at all, and they'd just keep waiting, Tess falling asleep on the couch with her cards, Pop sitting up by the window, Mom pretending to read, all night, and the next night, and the next?

He didn't know which would be worse.

He found that his face was wet. He couldn't wipe it. He sat on the cot with his hands locked behind his back and let it run, because there was no one to see, and then he was angry at himself for it, and then he was angry at everything, at the wardens and the Binders and the Ministry and Talia, *Talia*, who was up the hill right now in her tower with her white coat and her handler, and who had stood and watched while they did this to him.

The cold in the cuffs bit down. He gasped and bent double over his knees until it passed.

The bulb over the door flickered.

Owen looked up. It flickered again, a quick dimming, like someone passing in front of it. Then it was steady.

In the far corner of the cell, where the light didn't quite reach, the shadow looked deeper than it should have been.

He stared at it. It was just a corner. Just a shadow.

Some time later, he didn't know how long, the key turned.

Owen sat up so fast he nearly fell off the cot. But it wasn't anyone new. It was the warden from the motorcar, the one who'd held the iron box on his knees. Up close, in the yellow light, he was older than Owen had thought, with grey in his moustache and a face like a folded map. He had a tin cup in one hand.

He didn't say anything. He came over and held the cup to Owen's mouth, the way you'd help a small child, because Owen's hands were still locked behind him. It was water, cold and tasting of iron. Owen drank all of it. He hadn't known how thirsty he was.

The warden straightened up. He looked at the Binders on Owen's wrists, and then, for a long moment, at the dark corner of the cell. Something moved in his face.

"Listen to me, son," he said, very low, so that it wouldn't carry to the corridor. "Tonight, if the light goes out, you keep your eyes shut. You hear?"

Owen stared at him. "Why? What's..."

"And if anything talks to you," the warden said, "don't talk back. Don't you give it a single word. Not even *no*." He glanced at the corner again.

"The last boy in this cell talked back."

"What happened to him?"

The warden didn't answer. He took the empty cup and went out, and the key turned behind him, and Owen was alone with the corner again.

He was very tired. He'd been up since dawn. He'd crushed three hundred people into a marble floor. He lay down on his side on the cot, the only way he could with his arms locked behind him, and pulled his knees up, and kept his eyes on the corner until they closed on their own.

* * *

He woke to the sound of the key.

The door swung open, and a young man walked in, eating an apple.

He couldn't have been more than twenty-three. He was slim and pale, with neat dark hair combed flat and a pair of round wire spectacles, and he wore a grey suit so well cut it made Mr. Crane's look like a sack. There was a small silver pin on his lapel in the shape of a closed eye. He carried a thin brown folder under one arm. Behind him came a warden with a wooden chair, and another with the iron box.

"Don't get up," the young man said, around a mouthful of apple. "Well. You can't really, can you. Sorry about the irons. Regulations."

The warden set down the chair facing the cot. The other set the iron box on the floor beside it, and both of them went out and stood in the corridor, leaving the door open. The young man sat down, crossed his legs, and took another bite of his apple, and looked at Owen for a while with bright, interested eyes, the way Tess looked at a new trading card.

"Owen Calder," he said. "Sixteen as of this morning. Cable Street. Father's a stoker at Eastside, mother packs sardines, one little sister. Ten. Collects Grandmaster cards." He smiled. "I've read your file. It's not very long. It was about a paragraph until eleven o'clock this morning. It's a good deal longer now."

Owen pushed himself up to sitting, which took some doing. "Who are you?"

"Ansel Vey."

"Where am I?"

"The Low Office." Vey gestured around with the apple, at the stone walls and the bulb and the bucket. "Officially, it doesn't exist, and neither do I, and neither, as of about four hours ago, do you. But I find it's easier to talk to people if you give them some names, so there. Ansel Vey. The Low Office. You're in cell four." He took another bite. "Any other questions before I start? I'd get them in now. Once I start, I'm told I'm hard to stop."

"My family," Owen said. "Do they know where I am?"

"No."

"Are you going to tell them?"

"That," said Vey, "depends entirely on how the next hour goes." He said it pleasantly, the way you'd tell someone the tram was running late. "Anything else?"

Owen stared at him. His mouth had gone dry.

"Talía," he heard himself say. "Talía Reyes. Did she... Does she know about this place?"

Something flickered behind Vey's spectacles. Amusement, maybe. He looked at Owen for a moment longer than he needed to.

"Miss Reyes," he said, "has been very useful to us."

He let that sit in the air. Owen felt it land in his chest like a stone.

Useful.

"Right," said Vey brightly, and set the apple core on his knee. "Let's begin with a story. Stop me if you've heard it. You haven't. Nobody has, that's rather the point."

* * *

"You know about the seven Grandmasters," Vey said. "Everyone does. Flame, water, air, earth, light, ice, thunder. Seven great books, handed down from one holder to the next, painted in gold on the Bindery ceiling right over your head. Very inspiring. Very good for trading cards.

"What nobody knows is that there used to be fourteen marks on that ceiling.

"Seven gold. And seven dark.

"The dark ones were the other books. Time. Space. Gravity. Mind. Energy. Soul. They're older than the Grandmaster books. Some people who

study these things think the Grandmaster books were only made *because* of them, to have something to hold them back with. Nobody alive knows for certain. We made quite sure of that.”

“We?”

“The Ministry. The country. All of us.” Vey waved a hand. “About a hundred and twenty years ago, the six holders of the dark books went to war with one another. You may have wondered why there’s a stretch of the eastern coastline where nothing grows and the maps just say *Waste*. Or why the old capital is a lake now. That was them. Six people, and the country nearly didn’t survive it.

“So when it was over, we decided to forget. Officially. We painted over the ceiling. We burned the books that mentioned them. We took the dark marks out of every registry and every schoolbook and every prayer. We scraped them off the walls.” He nodded toward the corridor, at the gouged shapes between the doors. “It took about forty years, and it worked. Your grandparents never heard of them. Your parents never heard of them. You’d never heard of them until this morning, and you still haven’t, really, because nobody’s told you anything. Until me.”

Owen’s voice came out very small. “And my book is one of them.”

“Your book,” said Vey, “is Gravity.”

He leaned down and unlocked the iron box with a small key from his waistcoat pocket, and lifted the lid.

Owen’s book lay inside. Plain grey cloth. The dark mark on the cover. It looked smaller in here, somehow, and very ordinary, like any book you could find on any shelf. But the moment the lid came up, Owen felt it. A tug in his chest, deep under the cold of the Binders. Faint and far away, the way you feel a boat pulling on its rope when you’re standing on the dock.

The book felt it too. He was sure of that. It lay very still in its box, the way a dog lies still when it hears its name.

“Here’s the part they don’t put on trading cards,” Vey went on. “Each of the six dark books has something in it. We call them demons, because that’s the oldest word for them, and because nobody’s thought of a better one. Each demon is tied to a sin. Each one wants something, and each one gets a little of what it wants from whoever carries its book.” He ticked them off

on his fingers without looking, the way you'd recite a times table. "Time is Sloth, and its demon is called Sollumbre. Space is Greed: Karvesh. Mind is Envy: Visselth. Energy is Pride: Auranth. Soul is Lust: Lirrevain.

"And Gravity," he said, "is Gluttony. The hunger. Your demon is called Arcanula. She's the oldest of them, some say, and the hungriest."

He pronounced it carefully, the way you'd say the name of something you didn't want to hear you.

Owen looked at the book in the box. "She's... in there?"

"In there, and in you, a little, from this morning on. Don't worry. She'll be quiet for a while. They usually are, at first." Vey paused. "Tell me. When you had your hand on that book, and the whole hall was on the floor, how did you feel?"

Owen didn't answer.

"Light," Vey said softly. "You felt light. Didn't you? And just for a second, you liked it. Everybody looking at you. For once."

Owen's face went hot. He looked at the floor.

"That's Arcanula," said Vey. "That's how it starts. She's hungry, and she'll teach you to be hungry too. For weight, for space, for attention. She'll never be full. Keep that in mind." He smiled. "Anyway. That's six."

"You said seven," said Owen. "Fourteen marks. Seven dark ones."

"I did, didn't I." Vey looked pleased, like a teacher whose student had finally asked the right question. "Well spotted."

"There are six dark books. Six holders. But there's one more book, and it doesn't have a holder of its own. It has to be *earned*." He leaned forward on the chair, elbows on his knees. "It's called Reqrium. It means *all of them*. It holds the power of every other book, the six dark ones and the seven gold ones too, all at once, in one pair of hands. Its sin is Wrath.

"Here's how it works. The six dark books wake up, one by one, and pick their holders. Nobody chooses them. The books do the choosing. Then the six holders start to fill their books, page by page. When one of them fills every page, *every single page*, they can claim Reqrium. They become it. And the book they leave behind goes looking for someone new, so there are always six waiting, and one on top."

"How do the pages fill?"

“Three ways.” Vey held up three fingers. “Use: every time you push your power further than you’ve pushed it before, you earn a page. Feeling: grief, rage, fear, love, anything big enough to crack you open. And fighting, especially fighting the others. Nothing fills a dark book faster than beating another dark book.” He let his hand drop. “The last time someone claimed Reqrium, the old capital ended up at the bottom of a lake. So you can see why we take an interest.”

Owen’s mouth was dry as paper. “And the Reqrium book. Where is it now?”

Vey pointed over his shoulder, down the corridor, with the apple core.

“Two doors down,” he said. “Cell six. It’s been down here for sixty-one years, ever since its last holder died. Don’t worry. It can’t reach you through the walls.” He smiled. “Probably.”

* * *

“Now,” said Vey. “Here’s the part you’re not going to like.”

He opened the brown folder on his knee, glanced at something inside, and closed it again.

“When one of the dark books wakes up,” he said, “it almost always wakes up here. At the Bindery. On somebody’s sixteenth birthday, with their hand flat on a blank book, exactly like yours did. That’s why the Bindery exists, Owen. Did you ever wonder? A national office for registering everyone’s magic, in a building the size of a cathedral, with wardens on every wall? It isn’t there to give children their books. It’s a net. It’s there to catch the dark ones the moment they wake.”

He paused.

“And when we catch one,” he said, “we bring them down here, and we kill them. Before the book can start to fill. Quietly. Quickly. It doesn’t hurt, if it helps you to know that. We’re very good at it. We’ve been doing it for a hundred and twenty years. The book goes back to sleep for a while, and wakes up in someone else a generation later, and we do it again.”

The cell was completely silent. Owen could hear his own heartbeat. He could hear the bulb hum.

"That's what we'd normally do with you," Vey said. "Today. This afternoon. The paperwork's already filled out."

He opened the folder and turned it around on his knee so Owen could see.

It was a single typed page on thick cream paper, with the closed-eye seal stamped at the top in grey ink. It looked exactly like every other Ministry form Owen had ever seen: the ones Mom filled out for the ration office, the ones Pop signed at the station every quarter. Neat boxes. Neat typed lines.

HOLDER: *Owen Calder*. AGE: 16. ADDRESS: 41 Cable Street, 3rd floor. BOOK: *Gravity (Arcanula)*. DISPOSITION: and then a long empty line, and at the very bottom, beside a small printed X, another empty line for a signature.

Somebody had typed his address. Somebody had sat at a desk this morning and typed *41 Cable Street, 3rd floor* onto the same form they used to kill people.

"I'd just have to sign it," Vey said, and turned the folder back around.

"Then why..." Owen's voice cracked in half. He tried again. "Then why haven't you?"

"Because this time is different." For the first time, Vey's face lost its brightness. He looked, for a moment, almost his age. Almost tired. "For a hundred and twenty years, the dark books have woken up one at a time. A generation apart. One here, one there. Easy to catch. Easy to manage.

"This year, all six have woken up. In eleven months."

He let that land.

"You're the sixth, Owen. The last one. The other five are already out there. Some of them we caught and lost. Some of them never came near a Bindery at all. One of them is somewhere we can't follow, and one of them has already killed the wardens we sent to bring them in. And every day, all five of them are filling their books.

"Somebody is going to claim Requium. Soon. Probably within a year. We can't stop that anymore. All we can decide is *who*."

He leaned back in the chair.

"So the Low Office would like it to be somebody we're holding."

It took Owen a long moment to understand. When he did, it went through him like the cold from the Binders.

"You want *me* to..."

"Fill your book," Vey said. "Every page. Before any of the other five fill theirs. We'll train you. We'll feed you, house you, teach you, and when the time comes, we'll point you at the others. And when you've filled the last page, you walk into cell six, and you pick up Reqrium, and you become it. For us. Instead of for them."

"And if I say no?"

"Then I sign the paper." Vey said it gently. "This afternoon."

"And if I say yes, and I'm too slow? If one of the others gets there first?"

"Then you'll be the wrong person holding a dark book at the end of the world, and we'll sign the paper then." Vey spread his hands. "I won't insult you by pretending otherwise. You're not a prisoner, Owen, and you're not a guest. You're a horse. You're the fastest horse we've got, and we're betting the whole country on you, and if you stop running, we'll shoot you. I think it's better for both of us if you know that from the start."

He stood up. He tucked the folder under his arm and dropped the apple core into Owen's bucket.

"I'll give you until morning," he said. "Think it over. I'll leave your book with you. You can't open it with the Binders on, but I find people make better decisions when they can see what they're deciding about."

He knocked twice on the doorframe, and the wardens came in for the chair.

At the door, Vey paused and looked back.

"Oh, and Owen? Your family." His voice was perfectly pleasant again. "Right now, they've heard there was an accident at the Bindery. A gas main. Nobody seriously hurt. Unfortunately, one boy is still unaccounted for. Tomorrow morning, depending on your answer, they'll hear either that you've been found safe and taken on as a special scholarship student at a Ministry academy..." He smiled. "Or they'll hear something else."

The door closed. The key turned.

The iron box sat open on the floor in front of the cot, with the book lying inside it.

* * *

He didn't know how long he sat there.

There was no window and no clock, only the bulb. He sat on the edge of the cot with his hands locked behind him and stared at the book in the box, and the book lay still, and he thought about everything Vey had said until the words stopped making sense and were just noise.

Kill them. Before the book can start to fill.

Miss Reyes has been very useful to us.

You're a horse.

He thought about the old capital, which he'd learned about in school as a flood. A terrible flood, a hundred years ago, very sad. He thought about the eastern coast, where his geography teacher had said nothing grew because of the salt winds.

He thought about Talia. He couldn't stop.

Useful. Useful how? Useful the way Mr. Crane was useful, standing on the landing with his wristwatch? Had she known about this place when she shut the door on him? Had she known about the Binders, and the wardens, and the paper already filled out? Had she come to the Bindery this morning to watch him, because somebody told her to? *I'm going to stay until you're done.* Had she been told to stay, in case?

He didn't know. He didn't know, and there was no way to know, and the not knowing sat in his chest and burned. It burned hotter and hotter, the way a coal burns when you blow on it, until he could feel it pressing against the back of his teeth.

The bulb flickered.

Once. Twice. Then it went out.

The darkness was total. Owen couldn't see his own knees. He couldn't see the box. He sat frozen on the cot with his heart slamming, and his breath came loud in the silence, and he waited for the bulb to come back on.

It didn't.

But after a moment, he realized he could see something after all.

In the far corner of the cell, where the shadow had looked too deep this morning, there was a darker darkness. It was darker than the air around it, the way deep water is darker than shallow. It had a shape. It was tall, much too tall for the cell, so tall that it had to bend where it met the ceiling, folding over like smoke against glass. It had something like shoulders, and something like a head, bowed and turned toward him.

Where its eyes should have been, there was nothing. Just two places where the dark went deeper still.

Owen didn't scream. He wanted to. He couldn't find the air.

"There you are," said the shape in the corner.

Its voice didn't come from the corner. It came from everywhere. From the stone under his feet, from the iron of the cot, from inside his own chest. It was low and slow and rough, like a heavy thing being dragged across a floor, and it sounded pleased.

"I've been waiting," it said. *"Two doors down. Sixty-one years. And then this morning, I felt the whole building shake, and I thought: there. There he is."*

"Who..." Owen's voice was a thread. *"What are you?"*

"You know what I am. The pretty man with the apple told you." The shape leaned closer. It didn't move so much as grow, the dark spreading along the walls toward him. *"My name is Vorruk. I am the fury at the bottom of every heart. I am what's left when everything else is taken. I am Wrath, and I live in the book they can't give away, and I have been so very, very bored."*

The Binders on Owen's wrists had gone so cold they felt like they were on fire. He pressed his back against the stone wall.

"Oh, those," said Vorruk, sounding amused. *"Those were made for her. The hungry one. Arcanula."* The dark shape tilted its head at the book in the box. *"They were never made for me."*

"What do you want?"

"What do I want." Vorruk seemed to think about it. The darkness breathed in and out along the walls. *"I want what I always want. I want to be picked up. I want to be used. I want a pair of hands to hold me and a heart to burn in. I want you, Owen Calder of Cable Street, holder of Gravity, to fill that little grey book of yours faster than any of the others and walk two doors down and take me. That's what I want. I chose you this morning. I knew the moment the*

floor cracked."

"Why me?"

"Because you're angry," said Vorrुक, softly. *"You've been angry for five months. I could taste it through the stone before you even touched the book. All that weight, and nowhere to put it."*

Owen said nothing. His throat had closed.

"*She shut the door on you,*" Vorrुक said. Its voice was gentle now, almost kind, which was worse than anything. *"You stood on the landing with her name on a cake in gold, and she looked at you like a stranger, and she closed the door. And today she came to watch them take you. She stood there with her handler and her white coat, and she screamed very prettily, and she let them put you in the car. And the pretty man says she has been useful. Useful to the people who kill children in basements."*

"Stop it."

"*Five months, Owen. Not one letter. A card for your sister, to show you she remembered your address.*"

"Stop."

The Binders flared. Owen doubled over with a gasp, and in the dark he felt it, under the cold, the weight in his chest rising like water in a well, heavy and hot and so *good*, and the book in the iron box twitched. He heard it. The scrape of cloth on iron. The pages stirring by themselves.

"*There,*" breathed Vorrुक. *"Do you feel that? That's a page, trying to open. That's what anger does. That's how fast you could go, if you'd only let yourself."*

Owen shut his eyes. He shut them as tight as they would go and made himself think of something else. Anything else. Tess. Tess on the landing in her nightgown, eating stolen plums. Tess doing inventory. Pop's hand on his shoulder. *Good lad.*

Slowly, the weight sank back down. The book went still. The Binders eased from burning back to only cold.

When he opened his eyes, Vorrुक was still there. It hadn't moved. If anything, it seemed more pleased than before.

"*Clever,*" it said. *"Clever boy. Hold it down. Save it up. It'll keep."*

"I'm not going to let you..."

"Let me? I don't need you to let me anything. I only need you to be what you are." The dark shape leaned in until it filled the whole corner, the whole wall, until there was nothing in front of Owen but the two deeper places where its eyes should have been. *"But I'll make you an offer, because I'm fond of you already. Say my name. Just once, and mean it, and I'll take those irons off your wrists. I'll take that door off its hinges. I'll take this whole building off your back, the pretty man and his apple and his paper and his wardens, and you can walk up the ramp into the sunlight and go home to your little sister by supper."*

Owen's heart was pounding so hard it hurt.

"And the price," said Vorruk, *"is nothing. Nothing at all. Just a little room. Somewhere inside you, for me to sit. You'd hardly notice."*

For one long, terrible second, Owen wanted to.

He wanted to so badly he could taste the word in his mouth. *Home by supper.* Tess's face. Mom's hands on the sides of his face. The irons off. The door off its hinges. The pretty man and his paper, flat on the floor like everyone in the Bindery had been flat on the floor.

He bit down on his tongue until he tasted blood.

"No," he said.

The darkness didn't move.

"No?"

"No." He was shaking all over. "I'm not saying your name. I'm not giving you any room. Get out."

For a moment, there was nothing. Then, from everywhere at once, from the stone and the iron and the inside of his own chest, came a low, rolling sound, and it took Owen a long moment to understand that Vorruk was laughing.

"Oh," it said. *"Oh, I like you."*

"Then do it their way. Take the pretty man's deal. Fill your book. Fight the other five. Win. Come to me the long way round, one page at a time. It makes no difference to me." The darkness began to pull back into the corner, folding in on itself like smoke drawn up a chimney. *"You'll get here in the end. You'll just be angrier when you arrive."*

The bulb over the door flickered, and came back on.

The corner was empty. Just stone. Just a shadow, exactly as deep as it should be.

Owen sat on the cot and shook for a long time.

When the shaking finally stopped, he found he was looking at the book.

It lay in the iron box at his feet, grey and still, with its dark mark facing up at the ceiling. He'd forgotten it was there. Vorruk had filled the whole cell, and the book had just lain there under all of it, quiet, the way a dog lies quiet under a table during a thunderstorm.

Slowly, carefully, Owen stretched out one foot and nudged the edge of the box with the toe of his boot.

Nothing happened. He hadn't really expected anything. The Binders were still cold around his wrists, and Vey had said he couldn't open it with them on.

But after a moment he felt something anyway. Not a voice. Nothing like Vorruk, nothing that filled the room. It was so small he almost missed it: a faint, patient pull, low down in his stomach, like the feeling of skipping a meal. Not angry. Not cruel. Just *empty*, and waiting to be filled.

Hungry, Owen thought, and he wasn't sure if the word was his.

The pull didn't answer. It didn't need to. It sat there in the bottom of him, small and quiet and endless, and he understood that it would always be there now, the way the sound of the harbor had always been there on Cable Street, so constant you stopped hearing it.

Arcanula, Vey had said, carefully, like the name of something you didn't want to hear you.

Owen pulled his foot back from the box. He wrapped himself in the thin grey blanket as best he could with his hands behind him, lay down facing the wall, away from the corner, and kept his eyes shut. He did not sleep until morning.

* * *

The key turned early.

Ansel Vey came in without an apple this time, and without the chair. He had his brown folder under his arm and a fountain pen in his hand, uncapped, and he stood in the doorway and looked at Owen's face, and

whatever he saw there made his eyebrows go up slightly.

"Bad night?"

Owen didn't answer that. He'd spent the whole night deciding what he'd say, and now that the door was open, it was very simple.

"If I do it," he said. His voice was hoarse. "If I say yes. My family hears the scholarship story. Today."

"Within the hour. A very nice man with a very nice hat will knock on their door. Your sister will be tremendously jealous."

"And they're safe. Whatever happens to me. Nobody touches them."

Vey looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded, once, and something about the way he did it made Owen believe him.

"Nobody touches them," Vey said. "You have my word, for whatever the word of a man who doesn't exist is worth."

Owen looked down at the book in the iron box. It lay still. Waiting.

He thought about the five others, out there somewhere, filling their pages. He thought about the old capital at the bottom of a lake. He thought about the paper in Vey's folder with his name already on it. He thought about the door two down, cell six, and what was waiting in it.

He thought about the white towers at the top of the hill, and a girl in a white coat standing in one of those windows, being useful.

He thought: *I'll go up that hill one day. And when I do, I won't be waiting on the landing.*

"Then yes," Owen said. "I'll do it."

"Splendid." Vey uncapped the pen with his teeth, opened the folder against the doorframe, and signed something with a quick, neat flourish. It took him about a second. "Training starts tomorrow. Someone will bring you breakfast. Welcome to the Low Office, Mr. Calder."

He tucked the folder under his arm and turned to go.

"Oh," he said, over his shoulder. "And do try to get some sleep tonight. You look like you've seen a ghost."

The door closed. The key turned.

Owen sat alone on the iron cot in cell four, with his book lying open in its box at his feet, and the bulb humming over the door, and the Binders cold around his wrists.

Slowly, he became aware that the shadow in the far corner of the cell had grown a little deeper again.

He didn't look at it. He kept his eyes on the book.

But in the dark, very low, from somewhere under the stone, Vorruk laughed.

CHAPTER THREE

THE ALDREN INSTITUTE

They took the Binders off in the morning.

It was the old warden who did it, the one with the folded-map face. He came in with a ring of small iron keys and knelt behind Owen on the cot without a word, and there was a series of heavy clicks, and then a sound like a held breath let out, and the cold went away.

It went away all at once. One moment it was there, packed into Owen's arms and chest like frozen mud; the next it was simply gone, and in the space it left behind, something rushed back in. Owen gasped. It was like surfacing from the bottom of the harbor. His whole body was suddenly too heavy and too light at the same time, and the air in the cell tilted, very slightly, toward him, the way water tilts in a glass when you lean it.

The bulb over the door swung on its wire.

"Easy," said the warden, very quietly. He had one hand flat on Owen's shoulder blade. "Easy. Breathe. Let it settle."

Owen breathed. The bulb slowed. The air straightened itself out. After a while he found he could bring his hands around in front of him, and he sat there looking at them. There were red rings worn into both wrists, raw at the edges. His fingers shook.

"Thank you," he said.

The warden grunted. He stood up, slowly, one knee cracking, and hung the Binders on a hook on his belt, where they clinked against each other like a bad-luck charm.

"What's your name?" Owen asked him. "You never said."

The warden looked at him for a moment. Then he looked away.

"Doesn't matter," he said. "Won't be seeing much of each other after today."

"Why not?"

But Ansel Vey was in the doorway, and the warden stepped aside without another word.

* * *

Vey had an apple again. He also had a paper parcel tied with string, which he tossed onto the cot next to Owen.

"Clothes," he said. "You can't go up the hill smelling like cell four. Wash first. There's a basin across the corridor." He bit into the apple. "Then we'll have a little talk, and then you'll have a little drive, and then you'll have a whole new life, and I'll finally have my breakfast. It's a big day for both of us."

Owen looked at the parcel. He didn't touch it.

"Up the hill," he said.

"Up the hill." Vey smiled. "You've been wanting to go up that hill for five months, haven't you? Well. Here's your chance."

Owen's face must have done something, because Vey laughed.

"It's in your file," he said. "Everything's in your file." He pulled the wooden chair in from the corridor with his foot and sat on it backward, arms folded across the top, apple in one hand. "Now listen, because this part matters, and I'm only going to say it once.

"You're going to the Aldren Institute. You'll have heard of it."

Owen had. Everyone had. The Aldren Institute sat on the crown of the hill, right beside the Ministry towers, behind a wall so high you couldn't see anything over it but the tops of its spires. It was where the country sent the best of the best: the strongest fire, the fastest air, the kids who could lift a freighter or boil a lake. And the Grandmasters. Every new Grandmaster went to the Institute to learn how to carry what they'd been given. Every trading card in Tess's collection had *Aldren Institute* printed in tiny letters under the name.

It was where Talia had gone.

"You're our Gravity scholarship," said Vey. "A rare-power boy from the docks, found at the Bindery, sponsored by a generous and anonymous branch of the Ministry. That's what your file says upstairs. That's what the other students will be told, and it's what you'll tell them. You'll have

lessons. You'll have a bed with a real mattress and three hot meals a day and all the training anyone in this country can give. The headmistress knows what you really are. Nobody else does. Keep it that way."

"And if I don't?"

"Ah." Vey finished the apple and dropped the core into the bucket, the way he had the day before. "That's the other thing.

"Last night, while you were asleep, we gave you a little something." He said it lightly, as if he were talking about a vitamin. "Standard for the Low Office. You didn't feel it. You won't. It won't hurt you, and it won't get in your way, and you'll forget it's there. But if you run, or if you tell a living soul what you really carry, or if you hurt somebody we'd prefer you didn't hurt, then one night you'll go to sleep in your nice new bed and you simply won't wake up."

He tapped the side of his own neck, lightly, with two fingers, and smiled.

Owen's hand went to his own neck before he could stop it. There was nothing there. No mark. No scar. Just skin.

"I didn't feel anything," he said.

"You weren't meant to."

"When? When did you...?"

"While you slept," said Vey patiently. "I did say." He stood up and swung the chair back into the corridor with one hand. "Wash. Dress. The car's waiting. Welcome to the rest of your life, Owen."

* * *

The lift went up for a very long time.

Nobody put the Binders back on him. Two wardens rode with him, one on each side, and neither of them looked at him, and the iron box with his book in it sat on the floor of the cage between his feet. He could feel it through the iron. It was humming, faintly, like a kettle a long way off.

Then the cage stopped, and the gate opened, and there was the tunnel, and the motorcar, and the long curve of old brick going up. At the top the iron gates swung open by themselves, and the car rolled up the ramp beside the Bindery and out into the street.

Into the light.

Owen hadn't known he'd missed it. He'd only been underground a night and a day. But when the sun hit the windscreen he had to close his eyes, and when he opened them again the whole city was there, bright and loud and ordinary, and it was the strangest thing he had ever seen. Trams sparking on their wires. A newsboy yelling on the corner. A woman watering geraniums with one lazy finger, the way Mrs. Abernathy did. Nobody looking twice at a black motorcar going by.

The Bindery was closed. There were wooden barriers across the bronze doors and a painted sign propped against them: CLOSED FOR REPAIRS. GAS LEAK. REGISTRATION AT THE WREN STREET ANNEX. A policeman was standing beside it, directing a small crowd of sixteen-year-olds and their mothers around the corner.

Owen watched them go. He wondered if any of them had been in the hall yesterday. If any of them were telling their friends about the boy who'd crushed everyone flat.

Then the car turned onto Crown Avenue, and started to climb.

He'd walked partway up this hill a hundred times, but never to the top. The buildings got taller, and cleaner, and quieter. The shop signs changed from hand-painted wood to gold letters on glass. The motorcars at the curbs got longer and shinier. The people on the pavement wore hats that cost more than Pop made in a month. Halfway up, the tram lines ended, as if the trams weren't allowed any farther.

At the very top of the hill, the Ministry towers rose white against the sky, with the silver airship moored at the mast. And beside them, behind a high grey wall topped with iron spikes, stood the Aldren Institute.

It was bigger than Owen had imagined. It was old, much older than the towers, built of dark stone gone green in places, with spires and slate roofs and a great clock tower in the middle. The gates were black iron worked into the shapes of the seven Grandmaster marks, flame and water and air and earth and light and ice and thunder, all twisted together. The car rolled through them, and they closed behind it with a clang that Owen felt in his teeth.

And then he saw the students.

There were hundreds of them. In the courtyard, on the steps, leaning out of windows. They were his age and a little older, all in charcoal-grey coats with a thin stripe of colour at the cuffs: red for fire, blue for water, green for earth, and a dozen other colours he didn't know yet. Some of them were throwing a ball of water back and forth across the courtyard without touching it. Two boys were having a lazy argument with small flames flickering over their knuckles. A girl sat on the edge of a fountain, reading, while the pages turned by themselves in a breeze only her book could feel.

They all stopped when the car pulled up.

Owen saw it happen. He saw one head turn, then another, then a whole group by the fountain. He saw a boy lean over to whisper to a girl, and the girl's eyes go wide. He saw someone point.

He heard it, too, before he'd even opened the door. It came across the courtyard like wind across the harbor:

That's him.

The Bindery.

My cousin was there. She said the whole floor cracked.

She said he crushed a man's skull.

That's not true. It was a gas leak. It was in the papers.

Then why does he have wardens with him?

The warden on Owen's left opened the car door. Owen got out, holding the iron box against his chest, because nobody had told him not to, and stood on the gravel in his new clothes and his old boots while three hundred of the most powerful young people in the country stared at him.

He'd wanted to be seen. That was what he'd wished for, over the candle in the bun. *Something nobody could look straight through.*

Well. Nobody was looking through him now.

* * *

The headmistress's office was at the top of the clock tower, up a stone staircase so narrow and twisting that the wardens had to go single file. The door at the top was oak, and it opened before anyone knocked.

"Leave him," said a voice from inside. "And leave the box."

The wardens set the box down at Owen's feet, and went back down the stairs, and Owen was alone in the doorway.

The office was round, and full of books, and full of rocks. There were rocks on every surface: on the desk, on the shelves between the books, on the windowsills, in glass cases along the walls. Rough ones and polished ones, grey and red and green and one that was so black it seemed to drink the light. A huge clock face took up one whole wall, the back of the tower clock, its gears turning slowly behind the glass.

In front of it, in a heavy wooden chair, sat a very old woman.

She was small and upright, with iron-grey hair cut short as a man's and a face like a cliff: all hard edges, weathered in. She wore the white coat of a Grandmaster, but hers was old and plain and patched at one elbow, and the mark stitched on her shoulder was green. Owen knew that mark. It was on the second card from the left in Tess's collection.

The Earth Grandmaster.

"Ida Kessler," she said. "Headmistress of this Institute for thirty-one years, and Grandmaster of Earth for forty-four." She looked at him for a long time, the way you'd look at a crack in a wall to see if it was going to spread. "You're shorter than I expected."

Owen didn't know what to say to that. So he said nothing.

"Sit."

He sat, in a hard chair across the desk from her. The iron box he set on his knees.

"Put that on the floor," said Kessler. "You don't need to hold it like a baby. It's not going anywhere without you. It *can't*."

He put it on the floor.

"Ansel Vey tells me you're clever," Kessler went on, "and stubborn, and angry, and that you said no to the thing two doors down, which I will admit is more than most." Her eyes narrowed very slightly. "He also tells me you're the most dangerous child ever to walk through my gates, and that I'm to teach you to be more dangerous still. Do you know how many holders of the dark books I've met, Mr. Calder?"

"No, ma'am."

"Four," said Kessler. "In forty-four years. Every one of them was dead within the year." She said it flatly, without cruelty, the way she might have said it would rain. "I'm telling you that so you understand what I think the odds are. Not so you'll feel sorry for yourself. I don't have time for that and neither do you."

Owen's hands had curled into fists on his knees. He made them open.

"Here is how this will go," said Kessler. "In the mornings, you'll attend lessons with the other first-years. History, theory, discipline, the same as everyone. In the afternoons, you'll train with me, alone, in the Deep Room under this tower, where you can't bring anything down on anyone's head. At night, you'll sleep in the east dormitory with the other boys, because a boy who is locked away from everyone becomes a monster faster than a boy who has to share a washroom. Any questions?"

"Why are you helping them?" Owen said.

He hadn't meant to say it. It came out anyway. Kessler's eyebrows went up a fraction of an inch.

"The Low Office," Owen said. "They kill kids. In a basement. They showed me the form. And you're a Grandmaster. You're supposed to be..." He didn't know how to finish it. *Good*, he wanted to say. *You're on a trading card. You're supposed to be good.*

Kessler was quiet for a moment. Behind her, the great clock gears ground slowly around.

"I've seen the Waste," she said at last. "On the eastern coast. I went there when I was about your age, on a dare. Two hundred miles where nothing grows. Where the stones are melted into glass and the glass is still warm, a hundred and twenty years later." She looked at him steadily. "I'm not helping them, Mr. Calder. I'm helping whatever's left of this country after you six are finished with it. If that means helping them, then I'll help them. If it means helping you, I'll help you. If it means stopping you," she said, "I'll do that too."

She let that sit.

"Now get out. Your things are in the east dormitory, room nine. Trial's at noon. Don't be late. I hate late."

* * *

Room nine was at the end of a long, creaking corridor on the top floor of the east dormitory. It had two beds, two desks, two wardrobes, and one tall window looking out over the whole city, all the way down the hill to the harbor, so that Owen could see the cranes and the cannery smokestacks and, if he squinted, the grey smudge where Cable Street should be.

It also had a boy in it.

He was sitting on the bed by the window with his boots on the blanket, reading a newspaper. He was about Owen's height, with neat dark hair and a face that looked like it had never once been out in the rain. His coat had a red stripe at the cuff, and it fit him the way coats only fit people who'd had them made.

He didn't look up when Owen came in.

"You're on the wrong floor," he said. "The scholarship rooms are in the basement."

"This is room nine," said Owen. "They told me room nine."

The boy lowered the newspaper. He looked at Owen, at his old boots, at the iron box under his arm, and something went across his face that Owen recognized immediately, because he'd seen it on a hundred faces up and down Crown Avenue. It was the look you gave a stain.

"Oh," the boy said. "Oh, you're *him*."

He folded the newspaper very carefully and set it down.

"Julian Vance." He didn't hold out his hand. "My father sits on the Ministry council. My godfather is Cassius Rourke. You'll have heard of him, even on the docks." He tilted his head. "I asked for a single room. They told me there weren't any left. And then this morning they told me I'd be sharing with the *Gravity scholarship*." He said the words like they tasted bad. "So I'd like to know, Calder, before I go and complain to my father, what exactly you did to get a room on the top floor of the east dormitory, when your father shovels coal?"

Owen set the iron box down on the empty bed.

"How do you know what my father does?"

"Everyone knows." Julian picked up the newspaper again and held it up so Owen could see the page. There was a small paragraph near the bottom: BINDERY CLOSED AFTER GAS LEAK. NO SERIOUS INJURIES. And under it, smaller: *One boy, 16, of Cable Street, briefly unaccounted for, has since been found safe and awarded a Ministry scholarship.* "It's a very small town, once you get to the top of the hill. And people *talk*."

He looked at Owen over the top of the paper.

"My cousin was in that hall, you know," he said softly. "She says it wasn't a gas leak. She says you put her face into the floor so hard she broke a tooth."

Owen didn't say anything.

"She says you *liked* it," said Julian.

The window glass rattled very slightly in its frame.

Julian's eyes flicked to it. Then back to Owen. For just a second, something moved in his face that wasn't contempt.

Owen turned around, and put his things away in the empty wardrobe, and didn't say another word.

* * *

The noon bell was ringing when he came down into the courtyard, and the students were streaming toward the great hall on the north side, and that was where Owen saw Jonah Pike.

He saw the motorcar first. It was long and black, with a Ministry flag on the bonnet, and it had pulled right up to the steps of the great hall with a small crowd of students around it, and two men with flash cameras. As Owen watched, the back door opened, and someone climbed out, blinking in the sunlight, and the cameras went off *pop pop pop*, and the crowd cheered.

He was tall. Taller than Owen remembered. All long arms and long legs, with ash-brown hair sticking up in every direction like he'd just stuck his finger in a light socket. He was wearing a brand-new storm-grey coat with a gold mark stitched on the chest, and he looked completely terrified.

Jonah.

For a second Owen couldn't move.

They'd been born the same night, in the same hospital ward, twenty minutes apart, on either side of midnight. They'd had every birthday party together until they were ten. They'd learned to swim together off the end of Pier Six, and gotten caught stealing plums from the same barrow, and sat on the same roof on the same summer nights, him and Jonah and Talia, the three of them, eating those plums and spitting the stones at the gulls.

And then Talia had left. And Owen had stopped going up on the roof. He'd stopped going anywhere much. He'd stopped answering when Jonah knocked, and after a while Jonah had stopped knocking, and they'd become two people who nodded to each other on Cable Street and didn't say much else. Owen didn't even know when it had happened. It had just happened, the way the tide goes out.

Twenty minutes after midnight. Which meant that on paper, Jonah's birthday had been the day after Owen's. Which meant Jonah had gone to the Bindery yesterday, to the annex on Wren Street, with the main hall shut up for the gas leak.

And the Thunder book had been waiting.

Lightning doesn't strike the same street twice, Pop had said.

Jonah was looking around the courtyard with his mouth half open, like someone who'd woken up on the wrong tram. His eyes went over the crowd, and the spires, and the fountain, and then they landed on Owen, and stopped.

Owen watched his face change. Surprise, first. Then something that might have been relief. Then something more careful.

Jonah said something to the man with the camera, and pushed through the crowd, and came across the gravel toward him, fast, with his long legs, until he was standing right in front of Owen. Up close he smelled faintly of ozone, like the air before a storm.

"Owen," he said.

"Hey, Jonah."

"You're..." Jonah stopped. Started again. "They said you were missing. After the Bindery. Your ma was going door to door. Mine went with her. Then yesterday morning a man in a hat came and said you'd got a *scholarship*..." He was looking at Owen very hard. "And now you're here."

"I'm here."

"At the *Institute*."

"Yeah."

"With *Gravity*."

"Yeah."

Jonah looked at him for a long moment, and Owen could see him thinking, the way he did about once a week, when it mattered. Then he let out a breath and pushed a hand through his hair, which made it stick up worse.

"I got Thunder," he said. "Yesterday. At the annex. The ceiling of the little room lit up and I thought it was a fire and I tried to get out through a *window*." He laughed, but it came out shaky. "They kept me up the hill all night signing things, and this morning they put me in a car with the Prime Minister's flag on it, Owen. I've been sick twice."

Owen didn't know what to say. He found, to his surprise, that he wanted to laugh.

"You were always going to be sick twice," he said.

Jonah grinned. It was the same grin he'd had when they were seven. Then it faded, and he looked at Owen more carefully.

"You look like you haven't slept," he said. "Like, for a week. What happened, Owen? At the Bindery. For real. My ma heard the gas story, but Mrs. Delgado's cousin was *there*, and she says..."

"It was a gas leak," said Owen.

Jonah looked at him.

"It was a gas leak," Owen said again, "and I got lucky, and I got a scholarship, and here I am." He could feel the lie sitting in his mouth like a stone. He thought about Vey tapping two fingers against his neck. *If you tell a living soul*. "That's all."

"Right," said Jonah slowly. "Right. Okay." He was quiet for a second. "Talia came down to Cable Street last night, you know. First time in five months. She went to your door. I saw her from my window. She was talking to your ma on the landing for ages."

Something cold went through Owen's chest.

"She was probably told to," he said.

Jonah's eyebrows went up. "Told to? By who?"

But the noon bell rang again, louder, and a teacher in a black gown was on the steps of the great hall, calling out, "First-years! Trial! *Now*, please!" And the crowd was moving, and Jonah was being swept up in it by two men in grey suits who seemed to have appeared out of nowhere, and Owen found himself carried along through the great doors on his own.

* * *

The great hall of the Aldren Institute was built for this.

It was long and high, with a floor of bare stone and galleries running around the walls, crowded now with older students leaning over the rails to watch. At the far end, on a raised stone platform, sat the teachers in their black gowns. In the middle of them, in her patched white coat, sat Ida Kessler. And beside Kessler, in a long white coat with a gold sunburst stitched on the shoulder, her hair tied back in a high ponytail with a gold ribbon, sat Talia.

She was looking right at him.

Owen looked away.

In the middle of the hall floor, on a thick iron plate, sat a block of dark granite. It was about the size of a small motorcar. It had a groove worn around its middle, where a century of chains had been wrapped around it and taken off again.

"The Weighing Stone," said the teacher in the black gown, a thin man with a voice like a creaking door. "Two tons of Harbor granite. Every first-year who has passed through these doors for a hundred years has stood before it and done *something* to it. Lift it. Burn it. Freeze it. Crack it. Move it. It is not a test you can fail. It is a test of *what you are*. The masters will be watching. Names, please."

It went alphabetically.

A girl named Abbot soaked the stone until water ran off it in sheets. A boy named Aldous turned the top of it to rough sand. A girl named Beckett lifted it an inch off the plate with air, her face going purple with effort, and dropped it again with a *boom* that shook the galleries, to applause.

Then: "Calder."

It went quiet.

Owen walked out onto the stone floor. His boots sounded very loud. He could hear the whispers in the galleries stop, one by one, as people noticed who it was. He could feel three hundred sets of eyes on the back of his neck. He could feel one pair of golden ones on the side of his face, from the platform.

He stopped in front of the Weighing Stone.

His griamore was in his hands. They'd let him take it out of the iron box this morning, for the first time since the Bindery. It was heavier than it had any right to be. When he opened it, the first page was there, dark ink on old paper, the single word at the top: **Gravity**. And under it, in smaller writing he hadn't seen before, as if it had been there all along and he'd just never been close enough to read it:

Lighten. For a moment, the thing you name weighs nothing.

Press. For a moment, the thing you name weighs everything.

Pull. For a moment, everything falls toward you.

He knew, looking at them, that the last two weren't for today. He knew it the way you know not to put your hand on a stove. He could feel the weight of them on the page.

He could also feel the hunger.

It was right there at the bottom of him, the way it had been in cell four. Small and patient and empty. Except it wasn't small now. The book was open in his hands and the Binders were gone, and the hunger was *awake*, and it was looking at the Weighing Stone, and at the iron plate under it, and at the stone floor under that, and at the three hundred people in the galleries all around, and it was thinking, very quietly: *More*.

Pull, it suggested. *Just once. Just to see.*

His hands were shaking. He could feel the whole hall start, very gently, to lean.

"Mr. Calder." It was Kessler's voice, from the platform. Not loud. Very steady. "Whenever you're ready."

Owen closed his eyes.

He thought about the rope on the dock at home, drifting up like seaweed. The milk bottle hanging in the air above the kitchen floor. He'd

never done either of those things. He'd only daydreamed them, on the tram, a thousand times, wondering what it would be like to have a power like the kids on Tess's cards. But he could see them now as clearly as if he had.

The thing you name.

He opened his eyes and looked at the Weighing Stone. Only the stone. Not the plate, not the floor, not the people. *That* stone.

"*Lighten,*" he said.

The Weighing Stone rose.

It didn't jump. It didn't jerk. It lifted off the iron plate as smoothly as a soap bubble lifting off a basin, and it kept going, slowly, turning a little as it went: two feet, five feet, ten, until it was hanging in the air above the middle of the great hall at the height of the galleries, two tons of granite floating like a leaf on a pond.

Nobody breathed.

The older students in the gallery nearest it had flattened themselves back against the wall. One of the teachers on the platform had half risen from his chair. Owen could see the stone's shadow drifting slowly across the floor.

And the hunger at the bottom of him was saying, *Higher. Faster. Through the roof. Let them see. Let them all see what you are.*

He could feel his grip slipping. He could feel the stone wanting to go, the way a kite wants to go when the wind catches it. He could feel the hall starting to tilt again, just slightly, toward him.

He thought of Tess on the landing. He thought of Pop's hand on his shoulder. *Good lad.*

"Down," he whispered. "Down. Slowly."

The stone came down.

It came down slowly, turning back the other way, and settled onto the iron plate with a click so soft he barely heard it. Exactly where it had been. As if it had never moved.

Owen let go.

The pain hit him a second later, a white-hot spike behind his eyes, like the worst headache of his life arriving all at once, and he staggered and

caught himself with one hand on the cold granite. The book in his other hand had gone warm. He could feel it through the cover.

For a long moment, the great hall was completely silent.

Then someone in the upper gallery started clapping. Then someone else. Then a lot of people, and then the whole hall was clapping and stamping on the wooden galleries, and somebody was whistling, and the thin teacher was writing furiously in a ledger, and the noise came down on Owen like rain.

He looked up at the platform.

Kessler wasn't clapping. She was watching him, her cliff of a face perfectly still, and she gave him the smallest possible nod.

Beside her, Talia wasn't clapping either. She was looking at him with her hands pressed flat together in her lap, and her face had gone very pale, and Owen couldn't tell what she was thinking at all.

He walked back to the line on legs that didn't feel like his. As he passed the students still waiting their turn, he heard one of them whisper, awed, to another: "*That's the gas leak?*"

* * *

Jonah went after lunch, being a P, and the moment he put his hand on the Weighing Stone, a bolt of blue-white lightning came down out of nowhere, out of the ceiling, and split the granite straight down the middle with a crack like the end of the world. Every window in the great hall blew out at once. The galleries went absolutely wild. Jonah stood there with his hair on end and his mouth open, holding his book, staring at the two smoking halves of the Weighing Stone, and said, in a very small voice that nevertheless carried to every corner of the silent hall:

"*Sorry.*"

Julian Vance went near the end. He set the whole stone on fire, which was supposed to be impossible, and held it burning for a full minute, the flames going from red to orange to a pure hot white, while the older students whistled and stamped. When he walked back past Owen, he didn't look at him. But his jaw was very tight.

* * *

The Deep Room was under the clock tower, down another twisting staircase, so deep that Owen's ears popped.

It was round, like Kessler's office, and huge, and completely bare. The walls and floor and ceiling were all the same grey stone, smooth as glass, and scored all over with old marks: long gouges, starbursts of cracks, shallow craters, black scorch marks in the shape of hands. There was a single iron door. There was no furniture at all.

"Every Grandmaster in the last hundred years has learned to hold their power in this room," said Kessler. "And one or two other things besides." She stood in the middle of the floor in her patched white coat, and the stone under her boots seemed, somehow, more solid than the stone anywhere else. "Sit."

Owen looked around. "On the floor?"

"On the floor."

He sat. She stayed standing.

"You lifted the stone," she said. "Well done. It was the most controlled thing I've seen a dark holder do." She paused. "It was also the stupidest."

Owen stared up at her.

"You lifted two tons of granite over three hundred people's heads," said Kessler, "on your second day, with a demon at the bottom of you whispering *higher*. I heard it, Mr. Calder. I heard it in the stone. It was all I could do not to put that rock back on the plate myself." She crouched down in front of him, slowly, so their eyes were level. "Why didn't you just slide it an inch? Nobody would have thought less of you."

Owen opened his mouth. Closed it.

"Because they were all looking," he said at last.

"Yes," said Kessler. "Because they were all looking." She stood up. "*That's* what we're going to work on."

She taught him to breathe.

It sounded stupid. It sounded like something you'd teach a baby. But she made him sit on the stone floor with his book shut on his knees and breathe in for four counts and out for six, over and over, until he wanted to

scream, and then she made him open the book, and keep breathing.

"The hunger comes in on the in-breath," she said. "It always does, for your kind. Every gasp is it pulling. So you breathe *out*, Mr. Calder. Longer out than in. Every time. You empty yourself before it can fill you."

"How do you know that?" Owen asked. "About my kind?"

"Because I've done this four times before," said Kessler, "and I've watched four children die, and I made very sure to learn something from each of them."

He breathed. In for four. Out for six. The hunger at the bottom of him turned over and grumbled, and the Deep Room leaned very slightly toward him, and then settled again.

"Good," said Kessler. "Again."

They did it for an hour. Then two. Then she made him lighten a pebble, and keep breathing. Then a stone the size of a loaf of bread. Then she made him hold the stone in the air while she walked slowly around him, talking.

"Tell me about the girl," she said.

The stone wobbled.

"What girl?"

"Don't be tiresome. Miss Reyes. The Light Grandmaster, who sat on my platform this morning looking like she'd swallowed a knife, and whom you would not look at." Kessler kept walking. "Your file says you grew up together."

"My file says a lot of things."

"Keep breathing. Out for six." The stone steadied. "Your file says that she ended your friendship on the night she became a Grandmaster, without explanation, and that you've been angry about it for five months. Your file says the demon two doors down knew just where to press, and pressed there, and the whole cell shook." Kessler stopped walking. She was behind him now. He couldn't see her. "Your file says you think she betrayed you to the Low Office."

"She did," said Owen.

The stone jerked upward a foot.

"Out for six," said Kessler sharply.

"She did," Owen said again, and his voice cracked. "She stood there. She watched them take me. Vey said she's been *useful* to them. That's the word he used, *useful*, and she shut the door on me, I brought her a *cake*, and she..."

The Deep Room tilted.

It wasn't slight this time. The whole floor lurched toward him, and Owen felt the hunger roar up from the bottom of him like water up a well, and the stone in the air shot toward the ceiling, and cracks spidered out through the smooth grey floor from where he was sitting, and there was a sound like the whole tower groaning...

And then the floor *moved*.

It came up around him like a hand. The stone of the Deep Room rose in a smooth grey wave and closed over his knees and his hips and his chest, hard and cold, pinning his arms to his sides, holding him in place like a fist. The book slammed shut in his lap. The loaf-sized stone dropped out of the air and cracked on the floor beside him.

The weight went out of the room.

Owen sat there, encased to the shoulders in solid rock, gasping. Kessler walked around in front of him. She hadn't raised her hands. She hadn't opened a book. She was just standing there, a little breathless, looking down at him.

"That," she said, "is why we don't talk about the girl yet."

She let him sit in the stone for a full minute before she let him go. When the rock melted back down into the floor, it left him shaking and soaked in sweat, and his head was pounding so hard his vision had gone spotty at the edges.

"Tomorrow," said Kessler, "we'll do it again. And the day after that. And the day after that. Until the day comes when somebody says her name and the floor stays where it is." She turned toward the iron door. "Go and eat something. You look dreadful."

At the door, she stopped.

"For what it's worth, Mr. Calder," she said without turning around, "I've known Ansel Vey since he was nine years old. And he has never in his life used a word by accident."

Then she was gone.

* * *

Julian Vance was waiting for him in the courtyard.

It was nearly dusk. The lamps were coming on around the fountain, and most of the students had gone in to supper, but there were still a few dozen scattered around the benches and the steps. Owen came out of the clock tower with his head down, his book under his arm, and nearly walked into him.

"Calder," said Julian.

Owen stepped around him. Julian stepped in front of him again.

"Everyone's talking about you," Julian said. "Did you know that? The dock boy who floated the Weighing Stone. They're saying you're going to be the next great thing. They're saying the Ministry must have a very good reason to bring a Cable Street rat up the hill." He smiled. "I told them I know the reason."

"Move," said Owen.

"My father says the Ministry has a department," said Julian conversationally, "for dealing with *mistakes*. He wouldn't tell me which one. But he says every so often something comes out of the Bindery that shouldn't, and they take it somewhere underground, and it doesn't come back up." He tilted his head. "Except you came back up. So either you're not a mistake, or they haven't finished with you yet. Which is it, Calder?"

People had noticed. Owen could see them out of the corner of his eye, turning on the benches, drifting closer. A small circle was forming.

"Move," Owen said again.

"Or what?" Julian's hand came up, lazily, and a flame bloomed in his palm. Not a big one. Just big enough. It was white at the heart, the same white he'd burned the Weighing Stone with. "You'll do to me what you did to my cousin? In the middle of the courtyard? In front of *everyone*?"

The flame drifted closer to Owen's face. He could feel the heat on his cheek.

"You know what I think?" said Julian softly. "I think your father shovels coal because that's all your family's good for. I think your mother guts fish because that's all *she's* good for. And I think the only reason a dock rat like

you is standing in the Aldren Institute is that somebody up here is scared of you. And I think that's the only thing you'll ever be good for, Calder. Being something people are *scared of*."

It happened very fast.

The hunger came up from the bottom of Owen like a wave coming over a pier. It didn't ask. It didn't whisper. It *rose*, and the gravel around his boots flattened into the ground in a perfect circle with a sound like a slap, and Julian's flame bent sideways and down and slammed into the stones at his feet as if it had been yanked on a string. Julian staggered. His knees buckled, just slightly, just enough, and the look on his face as the weight came down on him wasn't contempt anymore. It was fear.

And oh, it felt *good*.

More, said the hunger. *He's so small. He's so light. Press. Press him into the stones like his cousin. Let them all see.*

The circle of students had gone dead silent. The fountain had stopped flowing; the water in the basin was lying flat and heavy as glass.

Owen stood there with his book shut under his arm, breathing hard, and felt Julian Vance sinking toward the ground in front of him an inch at a time, and wanted it so badly he could taste it.

If you hurt somebody we'd prefer you didn't hurt, said Vey, in his head, *you'll go to sleep one night and simply not wake up.*

And under that, quieter, Kessler: *Out for six.*

Owen breathed out.

He breathed out for a long time. Longer than six. Longer than he'd known he could. He breathed out until his lungs burned and there was nothing left in him at all, and the hunger at the bottom of him howled with frustration and then, grudgingly, went still.

The weight lifted.

Julian stumbled backward, gasping. The fountain spluttered back to life. Somewhere across the courtyard, a door banged open, and there was a sharp crack of thunder out of a clear sky, and a voice yelled, "*Oi!*"

Jonah came across the courtyard at a run, in his brand-new storm-grey coat, with tiny blue sparks snapping off the ends of his fingers.

"What's going on?" He skidded to a stop between them. He looked from Owen to Julian and back again. His hair was standing straight up. "What's *going on?*"

"Nothing," said Owen. His voice came out rough. "Nothing's going on."

Julian was staring at him. He'd gone very white. He opened his mouth, and closed it again. Then he turned on his heel and walked away across the courtyard, fast, and the circle of watching students parted to let him through, and didn't close again behind him.

Jonah looked at Owen.

"Owen," he said quietly. "What was that?"

"Gravity," said Owen.

"That wasn't..." Jonah stopped. He looked down at the gravel, pressed flat in a perfect circle around Owen's boots, smooth as a pond. He looked at the fountain. He looked back up at Owen, and for the first time since they were ten years old, Owen saw his old friend look at him like he wasn't sure who he was.

"That wasn't the gas leak either, was it," Jonah said.

Owen didn't answer. He walked past him toward the dormitory, and didn't look back.

* * *

She found him on the roof.

He didn't know how she knew. The east dormitory had a flat roof above the top floor, reached by a narrow iron ladder and a trapdoor at the end of Owen's corridor, and he'd found it by accident on his way back from the washroom, and he'd climbed up because it was the only place in the whole Institute where nobody was looking at him. From up here you could see the whole city. The lamps coming on down the hill, street by street. The harbor, black, with the lights of the freighters on it. Cable Street, somewhere in that grey smudge by the cannery.

It was the same view he and Talia used to look up at, from the other end.

The trapdoor creaked. He didn't turn around.

"Go away," he said.

"No," said Talia.

She climbed out onto the roof. He heard her boots on the tar paper. He heard her stop, a few steps behind him. He could feel the warmth coming off her, even from there, like sitting too close to a stove.

"Owen," she said. "Please. I need to talk to you."

"You've had five months."

"I know."

"You had my whole birthday. You had the whole Bindery. You could have said something then, and instead you just stood there with your *handler*." He heard his own voice going up and couldn't stop it. "You could've said something when they put the cuffs on me. Or when they put me in the car. Or last night, when you went to my *mother*, Talia, what did you tell her? What did they *tell* you to tell her?"

"Nobody told me anything!" Her voice cracked. "I went because she was *scared*, Owen, because nobody would tell her where you were, and I couldn't either, I didn't *know*..."

"You didn't know." He turned around. "You're a Grandmaster. You live next door to the Ministry. You sit on the headmistress's platform. And you didn't know that there's a place under the Bindery where they take kids like me and *kill them*?"

She went white.

"I didn't," she whispered. "Owen, I swear. I didn't know until..."

"Vey said you were useful."

"Vey?" Her whole face changed. "You met *Ansel Vey*?"

"He says you've been very useful to them."

"That's not..." She pressed both hands against her mouth. When she took them away, they were shaking. "Owen, I can't. I can't explain it. I'm not *allowed*. There's a rule. It's a stupid rule, and I hate it, and there are reasons for it I didn't even understand until last week, and if I break it, it's not me they'll..." She stopped. "It won't be me who gets hurt."

"That's convenient."

"*Please*." She took a step toward him. "Please, just give me a few more months. Just until spring. And then I'll tell you everything, I swear it on Tess's cards, I'll tell you all of it, and you can hate me then if you still want

to.”

“I brought you a cake,” said Owen.

She flinched as if he’d hit her.

“I spent every coin I had on it,” he said. “I stood there on your landing, and you looked at me like I was nobody, and you shut the door. And I sat on your step all night. *All night*, Talia. Waiting for you to come back out.” His voice was shaking so badly he could barely get the words out. “And you want me to wait until *spring*?”

He felt it then. The weight rising in him, hot and heavy, from somewhere much deeper than the hunger. Much older. The tar paper under his boots creaked and began to sag. The chimney stacks along the roof groaned. Down in the courtyard, far below, the water in the fountain went flat and still again.

Talia’s light flared.

It came off her all at once, bright and white and gold, the way it had in the Bindery five months ago, as if some part of her had reacted before she could stop it. The whole rooftop lit up as bright as noon. Every shadow on it jumped away and vanished.

All except one.

Owen saw her see it. He saw her eyes go past his shoulder, to something behind him, and he saw her face change. Every bit of colour drained out of it. Her mouth fell open. She took a step back, and then another, until her heel was at the very edge of the trapdoor.

“Owen,” she whispered. “Owen, don’t move.”

“What?”

“Behind you.” Her voice was barely a breath. “There’s something... behind you.”

He turned.

There was nothing there. Just the chimney stacks, and the dark sky, and the lights of the city down the hill. His own shadow, stretched out long across the tar paper by her light.

He turned back.

“There’s nothing...”

"It's *on* you." Talia's eyes were fixed on a point above his left shoulder, huge and horrified, and her light was flickering wildly around her. "It's standing right behind you. It's got its hand... Owen, it's got its hand on your shoulder. It's so *big*. It's got..." She pressed both hands over her mouth again. "It's got *horns*."

The weight in Owen's chest went very still.

For a moment neither of them moved. Then Talia's light guttered and dimmed, and whatever she'd seen, she stopped seeing it. Owen could tell by her face. The horror went out of it, and something else came in: something he'd never seen on Talia's face in the nine years he'd known her.

She was scared of him.

"Owen," she said. "What did they do to you?"

He didn't have an answer.

Talia looked at him for another long moment, with her hands pressed to her mouth. Then she turned, and climbed down through the trapdoor, and was gone.

Owen stood on the roof alone for a long time. Every so often he looked over his left shoulder. There was never anything there.

When he finally went down the ladder and back along the dark corridor to room nine, his book was heavier under his arm. He could feel it the whole way, dragging at him. When he got into the room and lit the little oil lamp on his desk and opened it, he saw why.

There was a second page.

He hadn't turned to it. He hadn't earned it. But there it was, freshly inked, the ink still gleaming wet on the paper as though someone had only just finished writing it. At the top, one word in dark letters:

Hunger.

And underneath, in smaller writing:

Whatever you take in, you keep.

He stared at it for a long time. He didn't know what it meant. He didn't want to know. He shut the book, and put it on the floor beside his bed, as far from his pillow as the room would let him.

* * *

Julian was already asleep in the bed by the window, or pretending to be, with his back very deliberately turned. There was a little flame burning in a glass jar on his nightstand, the kind rich kids used instead of oil lamps. It threw moving shadows over the ceiling.

Owen lay in the dark and watched them.

His head still ached from the trial. His whole body ached from the Deep Room. His throat ached from shouting at Talia. He could still feel the heat of Julian's flame on his cheek, and the look on Jonah's face in the courtyard, and the way Talia's voice had cracked in half when she said *horns*.

He lay very still and breathed. In for four. Out for six. In for four. Out for six.

He must have slept, because the next thing he knew, he was falling.

* * *

He was falling *up*.

That was the first thing he understood. He was falling, fast, the way you fall in dreams, with his stomach left somewhere far below, except that *below* was above him. He was falling toward the ceiling of room nine, and through it, and through the roof, and through the night sky above the Institute, and the stars were rushing past him *downward*, and the whole city was dropping away beneath his feet into the dark, and he couldn't breathe, and he couldn't scream, and he couldn't stop...

And then he landed.

Not hard. Not the way you land at the bottom of a fall. He landed the way you land in water, softly, sinking, until his feet found a floor.

He was standing in a hall.

It was the biggest room he had ever seen. Bigger than the Bindery. Bigger than the great hall of the Institute. It went on and on in every direction, into the dark, its ceiling lost somewhere so high up that he couldn't see it at all. And down the middle of it, running away from him so far that he couldn't see the end, stood a table.

It was a banquet table. The longest in the world. It was set for a feast, with a white cloth, and silver candlesticks, and plates, and goblets, and chairs, thousands and thousands of chairs, all pushed in neatly, all empty.

The candles were burning. But their flames didn't go up. They pointed *down*, all of them, dripping toward the table, as if even the fire in here was being pulled.

And the plates were empty. Every single one. Thousands of silver plates, polished to a mirror shine, with nothing on them at all.

Owen stood at the near end of the table in his nightclothes, barefoot on a cold stone floor, and heard, from somewhere far away down the length of that endless table, the sound of someone laughing.

It was a woman's laugh. Low and rich and amused. It came closer, and closer, with no footsteps at all, until it seemed to be coming from right beside his ear.

"Oh," said a voice. *"Oh, look at you. Look how thin you are."*

He turned around.

She was sitting on the table.

She was sitting right on the white cloth among the silver plates, with her legs crossed at the ankle, as if she'd been there all along. She was tall, taller than any woman he'd ever seen, even sitting down, and her skin was the pale grey-violet of a bruise just starting to heal. Her hair was black, and long, and it didn't hang down. It floated up and around her head in a slow dark cloud, drifting and curling the way hair floats underwater, as if gravity itself had given up on it. Two horns curved back from her temples, black and smooth and ridged, bending around and forward again like a pair of crescent moons.

There were marks on her skin. Thin glowing lines of pale gold, running down her cheeks from the corners of her eyes and along her collarbones and down her bare grey arms, curving and looping into shapes. After a moment Owen recognized them. They were crescents. The same crescent that was stamped in black on the cover of his book.

Her fingers ended in long black claws. She wore something dark and flowing that pooled around her on the table like spilled ink, and moved slightly, all on its own, the way smoke moves.

And her eyes...

The whites of her eyes were black. Pure black, like the inside of a well. And in the middle of each one was an iris of burning gold, ringed with

violet, fixed on him with an interest so bright and so total that he felt it on his skin, like heat.

She smiled.

She had a great many teeth.

"There you are," she said. "My boy. My little lightning rod. My hungry one."

Owen couldn't move. He couldn't make his legs work. He stood barefoot on the stone floor and stared up at her, and his heart was slamming so hard he thought it would burst.

"You're Arcanula," he whispered.

"Clever. He told you, did he? The pretty man with the apple?" She tilted her head. Her hair drifted with the movement. *"He always did say it wrong. Too much fear in it. You say it better."* She leaned down toward him from the table, until her face was very close, and she breathed in slowly through her nose, as if she was smelling something delicious. *"Mm. Say it again."*

He didn't.

She laughed again, delighted, and straightened up.

"Oh, you're stubborn. Good. I like stubborn. Stubborn lasts longer." She waved one clawed hand at the endless table, the thousands of empty chairs, the thousands of empty silver plates. *"Do you like my hall? I've been waiting in it for a very, very long time. All alone. No guests. No food."* Her golden eyes came back to him. *"Sixty-one years, since the last time anyone was brave enough to open my book and let me eat. Can you imagine? Sixty-one years with nothing on my plate."*

"What... what do you want?"

"What does anyone want, darling?" She smiled. *"I want to be full."*

She slid down off the table in one long, fluid movement, and suddenly she was standing in front of him, and she was tall, so tall he had to tilt his head right back to see her face. The dark stuff of her gown pooled around his bare feet, cold as harbor water.

"You fed me today," she murmured. "Did you know? Just a little. Just a taste. When you lifted the pretty rock and held it up for all of them to see, and you felt them watching you. When you pressed that boy into the gravel, and you felt him get small, and you liked it." She reached out with one long claw and very gently touched the center of his chest. It was so cold it burned. *"And on the*

roof. With the girl. Oh, that was lovely. That was the first real meal I've had in sixty years."

"Stop," said Owen. His voice came out tiny.

"I gave you a page for it," Arcanula went on, as if he hadn't spoken. "Did you find it? My present? Whatever you take in, you keep." She smiled wider. "That's the second thing we'll learn together, you and I. How to take. How to keep. How to swallow the whole world and never, ever be full."

And then, all at once, her face changed.

The smile went out of it like a candle blown out. Her golden eyes narrowed. Her hair stopped drifting and went flat and still around her head. When she spoke again her voice was different: colder, much older, and very, very quiet.

"He touched you."

Owen didn't understand. "What?"

"The brute. Two doors down. The one who calls himself Wrath." Her claws came up and closed, very lightly, around the back of his neck. "I can smell him on you. He put his hand on your shoulder in the cell. And again tonight, on the roof, while the girl watched. He stood behind you like he owned you."

Her grip tightened, not quite enough to hurt.

"You are not his," said Arcanula. "You were never his. You are mine. I woke for you. I chose you. I am the one who lives in your book and in your belly and in the dark at the bottom of you, and I will be the one who fills you up, page by page, until there's nothing left in this world you can't pull down. And when you finally walk into that cell of his, you'll walk in full of me. And we'll see how he likes being eaten."

For a moment she held him there, her burning golden eyes an inch from his, and Owen understood, with a certainty that went all the way to his bones, that she was the oldest thing he had ever met. Older than the Waste. Older than the old capital. Older than the city on the hill and the harbor below it and the first boat that ever tied up there. She had been hungry when the whole world was mud.

Then, just as suddenly, she let go, and laughed, and it was the playful laugh again, rich and warm and delighted, as if none of it had happened.

“Oh, look at your face,” she said. “You’re shaking. Poor thing. Poor little thing. You haven’t had a proper meal in days, have you? Neither have I.”

She turned, and her gown swept out behind her, and she walked away from him along the side of that endless table, trailing one claw along the white cloth so that it tore, very slightly, in a long thin line. The candles leaned toward her as she passed, their downward flames all bending her way.

Halfway along, she stopped, and pulled out one of the thousands of empty chairs. Then she turned and looked back at him over her shoulder, with her black-and-gold eyes, and her floating hair, and her crescent horns, and all her teeth.

“Well?” said Arcanula. “Come here, Owen Calder. Sit down.”

She patted the chair.

“It’s time we had dinner.”

CHAPTER FOUR

A SEAT AT THE TABLE

“No,” said Owen.

His voice came out thin and small in that enormous hall, and it didn’t echo. Nothing in here echoed. The sound just fell out of his mouth and dropped to the stone floor and lay there.

Arcanula tilted her head. Her black hair drifted with the movement, slow as weed in a tide.

“*No?*”

“I’m not sitting down.” He made himself look up at her, into those black-and-gold eyes. “I’m not eating anything. I’m not doing anything you say. You’re a...” He didn’t know the word. “You’re a *thing* that lives in a book. I don’t have to do what you want.”

For a moment she only looked at him. The candles along the endless table had all gone still, their downward flames hanging motionless, as if the whole hall were holding its breath.

Then she smiled, very slowly, with every one of her teeth.

“*Oh, darling,*” said Arcanula. “*You’re standing in my stomach.*”

She crooked one long black claw.

The floor tipped.

It didn’t tilt the way the Bindery had tilted, or the Deep Room. It *tipped*, all at once, as if the whole enormous hall had been a tray and somebody had picked up one end. Owen’s bare feet went out from under him. He hit the stone on his side and slid, fast, across the cold floor toward her, and he grabbed at the legs of chairs as he went past and they didn’t move, they were fixed there like iron posts, and his fingernails scraped on stone and found nothing to hold, and then the chair she was holding out was rushing up at him and he slammed into the seat of it so hard it knocked the breath out of him.

The floor tipped back. The chair scraped forward on its own and tucked him in against the table, neat as a waiter.

He couldn't get up. He tried. His arms and legs had gone heavy, so heavy he could barely lift his fingers off the white tablecloth. It was the same weight he'd poured out over the Bindery floor, the same weight that had pressed Julian toward the gravel. Now it was his turn to feel it, and it was *awful*. It pressed on his chest. It pressed on his eyelids. It held him in the chair like a hand.

"*There,*" said Arcanula, pleased, and sat down across from him. "*Much better. Nobody likes to eat alone.*"

She didn't pull out a chair. She simply sat, and one was there under her, a high carved thing black as her horns, and she leaned her elbows on the table and rested her chin on her folded claws and looked at him across the empty silver plate between them.

"*Now,*" she said. "*Let's talk about what's for dinner.*"

* * *

"*You've met the brute,*" said Arcanula.

It wasn't a question. Owen said nothing. He was concentrating on breathing. In for four. Out for six. It didn't seem to help much in here.

"*He's told you he chose you.*" She traced a slow circle on the tablecloth with one claw. "*He's told you he wants you to walk into his little cell and pick him up and carry him around forever. Has he told you why?*"

"He said he was bored."

Arcanula laughed. It was a real laugh, sudden and delighted, and the candle flames all shivered with it.

"*Bored. Oh, that's good. That's very good. I'll give him that one.*" She leaned closer. "*No, darling. He's not bored. He's frightened.*"

"Of what?"

"Of me."

She let that sit on the table between them like a dish.

"*Let me tell you a secret,*" she said. "*The pretty man with the apple doesn't know it. The old stone woman doesn't know it. Nobody in your whole city knows it, because nobody has lived long enough to watch it happen twice.*" She held up

one claw. *"When one of the six fills their book and walks into that cell and picks up Reqrium, they don't go alone. We come with them. The demon in their book climbs up into the new one, like a crab moving into a bigger shell."* A second claw. *"And the demon that was already sitting in Reqrium? He doesn't get to stay. He gets pushed out. He falls down into the empty book that was left behind, and he sits there, and he waits for some other child to come along and pick him up."*

Owen stared at her.

"So," said Arcanula softly, "if the boy who takes Reqrium is carrying the Time book, then Sollumbre becomes Wrath, and the brute falls down to be Sloth. If it's the Mind book, then Visselth goes up, and he falls down to be Envy. And if it's you, my darling, if it's the Gravity book that walks into that cell..."

She spread her claws, smiling.

"Then I become Wrath. And Vorruck falls into my hall, to sit at my table, in front of my empty plates, and be hungry for sixty years."

The candles leaned toward her. Owen could feel his heart going very hard in his chest, under the weight.

"That's why he picked me," he said slowly. "He wants me because... because I've got you. So he can..."

"So he can climb inside you first," said Arcanula. "Yes. So that when you walk in, you'll already be his. So that when we come up the stairs together, he'll already be sitting in your chest, and there'll be no room for me, and he'll stay right where he is, on top, forever. That's what the little room was for, Owen. The one he asked you for. The one you said no to." She sat back. *"Clever boy. I told you I liked stubborn."*

Owen's mouth was very dry.

"And you want the opposite," he said. "You want me to get there first, with you, so you can climb up and he falls down."

"I want to be full," said Arcanula. "And there is nothing in this world more filling than Wrath."

* * *

"So here's my offer," she said.

She snapped her claws. The silver plate in front of Owen, the one that had been empty, wasn't empty anymore. There were three things on it. He

couldn't have said afterward what they looked like. They weren't food. They were more like *ideas* that had been given a shape and a shine and put on a plate, and when he looked at each one, he knew what it was the way you know things in dreams.

"One," said Arcanula, and touched the first with a claw. *"Speed. You'll fill your book faster than any of the other five, because I'll help you. I know every page in it. I know what's written on the last one. I'll show you how to get there, one meal at a time."*

"Two." She touched the second. *"Him. The brute. While I'm awake inside you, he can't lay one finger on you. Not in the cell. Not on the roof. Not anywhere. I'll stand behind you, where he stood, and he'll have to go around."*

"And three." The third thing on the plate shone brighter than the others. *"The truth. About everything. The girl and her little locked door. The pretty man and his little lies. What the old stone woman really wants with you. I'll tell you all of it. Eventually."*

"When?"

"Dessert," said Arcanula, and smiled. *"Truth is always dessert."*

"And what do you want for it?"

She didn't answer right away. She looked at him across the table, and for once there was no playfulness in her face at all. Just hunger. Old and patient and bottomless.

"Now and then," she said quietly, *"I'd like to go for a walk."*

He didn't understand at first. Then he did, and the cold went all the way down his back.

"Not often," said Arcanula. *"Not for long. An hour here. An afternoon there. I've been sitting at this table in the dark for sixty-one years, darling. I'd like to feel the sun. I'd like to taste something that isn't the inside of a book."* She tilted her head. *"With your mouth. With your hands. In your shoes. And then I'll give them back, a little more full than I found them."*

"You want to be me."

"Only sometimes."

"No."

"No?" Her eyebrows went up. *"Then say no, and wake up, and go back to your nice new bed and your nice new school, and see how long you last. See how*

long you last when the brute comes back tonight, and tomorrow night, and every night after that, standing behind you on every roof with his hand on your shoulder, whispering about that girl. See how long it takes him to find his little room.” She leaned in. “You felt him on the roof, didn’t you? The weight that came up out of you when the girl said spring. That wasn’t me, darling. That was him. And he’d only just started.”

Owen didn’t say anything.

“Or,” said Arcanula, and her voice went soft again, almost gentle, “you could say yes. And I’ll stand between you and him. And you’ll go faster than all of them. And one day you’ll walk into that cell and pick up the whole world, and he’ll fall down here into the dark where he belongs. And you’ll only have lent me your shoes once in a while.”

She held out her hand across the table. Long grey fingers. Black claws. The thin gold crescents on her wrist glowing faintly.

“Well?”

Owen looked at her hand for a long time.

He thought about the corner of cell four, and the dark folding against the ceiling like smoke. He thought about Talia’s face on the roof, gone white, her hands over her mouth. *It’s got its hand on your shoulder.* He thought about Vey’s form with his address typed on it. He thought about five other kids, somewhere out there, filling their books.

He thought about his mother saying: *Things you leave too long get heavy.*

“Only sometimes,” he said. *“An hour. Not more. And you give it back.”*

“Only sometimes,” Arcanula agreed.

“And you don’t hurt anyone. When you’ve got my hands. You don’t hurt my family, or Jonah, or...” He stopped. *“Or anyone.”*

Arcanula smiled.

“I won’t hurt anyone you love,” she said.

He knew, even then, that it wasn’t the same thing. He knew it the way you know a step is missing in the dark. But the weight on his chest was so heavy, and she was so close, and the thought of Vorrुक standing behind him every night was so much worse.

He lifted his hand off the tablecloth. It took everything he had. And he put it in hers.

Her claws closed around it. They were so cold they burned, like the Binders had burned, like iron in winter, and something went into his palm from hers, a sharp bright sting, like a splinter of ice going in under the skin.

"There," whispered Arcanula. *"Now we're family."*

And the whole hall fell *upward*, and the candles went out, and Owen woke up in room nine with a gasp, in the grey light of dawn, soaked in sweat and clutching his right hand against his chest.

He opened it.

In the middle of his palm, faint and silvery, like an old scar that had been there for years, was the shape of a crescent moon.

* * *

Julian's bed was empty and neatly made. The flame in the glass jar on his nightstand had gone out.

Owen sat on the edge of his own bed in the grey light and stared at the mark on his palm until the breakfast bell rang. It didn't hurt. It didn't do anything. It just sat there, pale and quiet, the way the hunger sat at the bottom of him, and when he closed his fingers over it, he could feel, very faintly, something like a smile.

Good morning, darling, said a voice in the back of his head. *I'm starving.*

He went down to breakfast.

The dining hall at the Aldren Institute was a long, high room with tall windows and six long tables, and it smelled of coffee and toast and floor polish. Owen took his tray to the far end of the last table, where nobody was sitting, and nobody came to sit near him. That was fine. He could hear them anyway. *Bindery boy. Gas leak. Julian's roommate. Where's Julian?* The whispers slid along the tables and around him like water around a stone.

He ate two bowls of porridge. Then he went back up and got a third.

He ate four slices of toast, and three boiled eggs, and a sausage somebody had left on the serving tray, and a heel of bread he found at the bottom of the basket. He ate until his stomach hurt. It didn't help. The food went down into him and vanished, the way a stone vanishes into a well, and the empty place at the bottom of him stayed exactly as empty as it had

been.

And it wasn't only the food.

He noticed it halfway through the third bowl. A first-year girl two tables down had dropped her cup, and it had smashed, and she'd gone bright red, and for one second Owen had *felt* it. Her embarrassment. It had come across the room to him warm and sharp, like the smell of something frying, and the hunger at the bottom of him had lifted its head and *sniffed* at it.

He put his spoon down.

He looked along the tables, at all the whispering faces, and he felt them. Not their words. The things underneath. Curiosity, bright and thin as sugar. Fear, darker and richer. A boy by the window who was nervous about an exam, and a girl by the door who was homesick, and somebody, somewhere, who was very, very angry about something, and all of it was drifting toward him on the warm air of the dining hall like steam off a kitchen, and all of it smelled *good*.

Isn't it lovely? murmured Arcanula. *All these little dishes. And nobody's even touching them.*

Owen pushed his tray away, and breathed out for a long time, and walked out of the dining hall with his hands in his pockets, and was still hungry when the bell went for lessons.

* * *

The first lesson of the morning was Grandmaster Lore, and it was taught by the thin teacher with the creaking-door voice, whose name turned out to be Master Quill.

It was held in a long, sunny classroom on the second floor of the north wing, with rows of old wooden desks and a huge painted map of the country on one wall. The first-years sat at the desks. At the front, on a separate bench, sat the handful of students who wore white or grey coats instead of charcoal: the Grandmasters, who apparently took Lore with everyone else, because, as Master Quill said, "a Grandmaster who does not know their own history is merely a very loud accident."

Talia was on the bench. So was Jonah, looking uncomfortable in his new storm-grey coat, with his knees up around his ears because the bench was too low for him.

Owen took a desk at the very back.

He'd barely sat down when the chair beside him scraped, and Jonah dropped into it, having apparently climbed over two rows of desks to get there.

"You're supposed to sit on the bench," Owen said.

"The bench is for people with short legs." Jonah stretched his out into the aisle with a sigh of relief. "And people who like being looked at. Talia's on it. That's two strikes." He glanced sideways at Owen. "You look terrible, by the way."

"Thanks."

"No, I mean it. You look like you've been up all night fighting a bear." Jonah frowned. "What's wrong with your hand?"

Owen closed his fist. "Nothing."

Jonah looked at him for a second. Then, to Owen's surprise, he let it go. He just nodded, and turned to face the front, and opened his textbook, and Owen felt something in his chest unclench very slightly that he hadn't even known was clenched.

"*The Seven*," said Master Quill, and tapped the blackboard with a long pointer. "*A History*. Chapter One. Open your books."

The textbook was old and thick and bound in green cloth, with the seven Grandmaster marks stamped in gold on the cover. Owen opened it to the first page, and there was a picture there, a full-page engraving of the Bindery ceiling: seven marks in a ring, flame and water and air and earth and light and ice and thunder, each one in its own careful circle.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he looked closer.

The ring wasn't a ring. Not really. The seven marks were spaced out evenly all the way around, but between each pair of them there was a gap. A gap exactly the size of another mark. And in each gap, if you tilted the page toward the window and let the morning light slide across it, you could see that the engraving had been scraped. Very carefully. Somebody, a long

time ago, had taken a fine blade to the printing plate, and cut something away, seven times, and filled the spaces in with a pattern of little stars.

Owen ran his thumb over one of the gaps. The paper was smooth. You'd never have known, if you hadn't seen a stone corridor with seven shapes gouged out of its walls.

"Mr. Calder."

He looked up. Master Quill was staring at him down the length of the classroom. So was everyone else.

"You seem very absorbed in the frontispiece," said Master Quill. "Perhaps you could tell us what you find so fascinating about it."

The room had gone quiet. Owen could feel them all waiting. *The Bindery boy. The gas leak.*

"There's gaps," he said. "Between the marks. Like something's missing."

For just a second, something moved in Master Quill's face. Then it was gone.

"Decorative spacing," said Master Quill crisply. "The engraver's choice. Page three, everyone, please. The Founding of the Flame."

And he turned back to the blackboard. But Owen saw his hand, holding the chalk, and it was not quite steady.

The rest of the lesson was the Founding. Master Quill told it the way he must have told it a hundred times, in his creaking-door voice, pacing up and down in front of the painted map: how the seven great books had first been found, long ago, in the time before the old capital; how the first Grandmasters had carried them into the wars and out again; how a Grandmaster book never dies and never sleeps, but only waits, when its holder goes, for the next sixteen-year-old hand to touch it.

"Which is why," said Master Quill, "the passing of a Grandmaster is both a funeral and a birth. Mr. Pike can tell us something about that, I imagine."

Jonah, who had been drawing a very small storm cloud in the margin of his textbook, sat up fast. "Uh. Yes, sir. It's... it's weird, sir."

"Eloquently put." Master Quill made a note on the board. "*Weird*. I shall submit it to the Royal Society."

Everyone laughed. Even Owen, a little. It felt strange in his mouth, like a word in a language he'd forgotten.

He didn't hear most of what came after. He sat with his thumb on the scraped gap in the engraving and let Master Quill's voice go past him. Seven gaps. Seven stars. Seven marks cut out of a printing plate by someone with a very steady hand, a very long time ago, so that a whole country could open its schoolbooks every morning for a hundred years and never once wonder what was missing.

They were very thorough, said Arcanula, in the back of his head. *I'll give them that. They were very, very thorough.* A pause. *It didn't help them in the end.*

On the bench at the front, Talia had turned around. She was looking straight at Owen down the length of the room, over the heads of all the other students, and her face was very serious, and he thought, for one strange moment, that she was about to say something.

Then her eyes moved. Just slightly. Up, and to the left, to a point above his shoulder.

He watched the colour drain out of her face the way it had on the roof. He watched her lips go white. She turned around so fast that she knocked her textbook off the bench, and it hit the floor with a slap, and Master Quill said "Miss Reyes," in a pained voice, and she bent to pick it up with shaking hands and didn't turn around again for the rest of the lesson.

She can see me, said the voice in the back of Owen's head, delighted. *Oh, isn't that sweet. The little lamp can see me.*

Owen stared at the back of Talia's head, and the gold ribbon in her hair, and felt sick.

* * *

At lunch, a boy two tables over was reading a newspaper, and he read the headline out loud to his friends as a joke, in a spooky voice.

"*WHOLE VILLAGE SLEEPS THREE DAYS,*" he intoned. "*Marrowford Residents Wake to Stopped Clocks, Missing Time.*" He grinned. "Listen to this. *Every one of the three hundred residents of the farming village of Marrowford, forty miles north of Port Aldren, fell asleep on the evening of the fourteenth and did not wake until the morning of the seventeenth. All clocks in the village were*

found stopped at eleven minutes past nine. Livestock, too, appear to have slept. Doctors are baffled." He wiggled his fingers. "Ooooh. Baffled."

His friends laughed.

Owen had stopped eating.

Time is Sloth, Vey had said, ticking it off on his fingers. *And its demon is called Sollumbre.*

Wanting to stop the clock, he thought, *and never have to move.*

Beside him, Jonah was laughing too. Then he noticed Owen's face, and stopped.

"What?" he said. "It's just some farmers having a lie-in."

"Yeah," said Owen. "Probably."

But under the table, he closed his hand over the crescent on his palm, and he felt, very distinctly, Arcanula go still inside him. The way a cat goes still when it hears something in the walls.

Sollumbre, she said softly. *Lazy old thing. Awake already.* A pause. *Forty miles. That's not very far, darling. Not very far at all.*

* * *

In the Deep Room that afternoon, Kessler made him breathe for an hour, and then made him lighten a boulder the size of a cart, and then made him put it down again very slowly, and then made him do it all again.

Halfway through the third time, she stopped walking.

"Show me your right hand," she said.

Owen went still. The boulder hung in the air above him.

"Put the rock down, Mr. Calder. Slowly. Then show me your hand."

He put the rock down. He held out his hand, palm up, because there didn't seem to be any point in doing anything else.

Kessler looked at the crescent for a long time. She didn't touch it. Her cliff of a face didn't move. But the stone floor of the Deep Room, all around them, made a very small sound, like something heavy settling.

"When?" she said.

"Last night."

"In a dream."

"Yes."

"And she dragged you to the table, and you said no, and it didn't matter, and then she offered you everything you wanted, and asked for something that didn't sound too bad." Kessler closed her eyes briefly. "And you said yes."

Owen stared at her. "How do you...?"

"Every one of the four made a deal, Mr. Calder." Kessler opened her eyes. "Every single one. They all had a mark, somewhere, afterward. One on the wrist. One on the back of the neck. One behind the ear, under her hair, where she thought nobody would see." She looked at his palm. "Not one of them ever told me what they'd agreed to. Not until it was far too late."

She was quiet for a moment.

"What did you promise her, Mr. Calder?"

Owen closed his hand.

He thought about telling her. He wanted to, in a strange way. Kessler was the only person in the whole city who seemed to understand what was happening to him, and she was standing right there, small and upright and grey, waiting. It would be easy. *She wants to go for a walk. Sometimes. An hour.* It sounded like nothing, said out loud. It sounded almost sweet.

And at the bottom of him, very gently, like a finger laid against his lips, something said: *Shh*.

"Nothing much," said Owen.

Kessler looked at him for a long time.

"That," she said, "is what the one with the mark behind her ear told me. Word for word." She turned her face away, toward the far wall of the Deep Room, where the lamplight didn't quite reach. "She was fifteen days from her seventeenth birthday. She liked oranges. She used to peel them in one long curl and give me the peel, because she said it smelled like summer." Her voice didn't change at all. "I kept one, for a while. In my desk. It went hard and brown, and one day I threw it away."

Owen didn't know what to say. So he didn't say anything.

"Again," said Kessler, without turning around. "The boulder. And this time, I want you to breathe out for eight."

* * *

The sparring class was held in the old armory, a long, low stone building on the west side of the courtyard with sand on the floor and racks of padded practice staves along the walls. It was taught by a huge, bald, scarred man named Master Brand, who had been in the army and still walked like it, and who had apparently only one rule, which he shouted at them as they came in:

"Nobody dies on my sand!"

He paired them off by pulling names out of a leather bag. The first pairs were ordinary: a boy with air against a girl with water, a strength kid against a metal kid. They circled each other on the sand while Master Brand bellowed advice, and nobody got hurt worse than a few bruises.

Then Master Brand pulled out a slip of paper, looked at it, and paused.

"Vance," he said. "And..." He looked at the next slip. "Calder."

Owen looked across the sand. Julian Vance was already looking back at him. He'd been looking at Owen since they walked in. There was no expression on his face at all, but his hands were curled into fists at his sides, and small wisps of smoke were rising from between his fingers.

"Sir," said Julian. "I'd like to go first."

"You're both going first, Vance. That's how pairs work." Master Brand stepped back to the edge of the sand. "Standard rules. Three points. First to a clean touch, or a yield. *Nobody dies on my sand*. Begin."

They circled.

Julian struck first. It was a clean, fast, textbook shot, a spear of orange fire as thick as a broom handle, aimed low at Owen's legs, and Owen didn't think. He said "*Lighten*," to himself, to his own body, the way Kessler had made him practice a hundred times on the boulder, and the sand dropped away beneath his boots.

He went up. Not far. Maybe four feet. The fire went under him and splashed against the far wall in a shower of sparks, and he hung there for one long, astonished second, weightless, with his coat floating out around him, and then he remembered that he hadn't planned how to come down and came down all at once, sideways, and landed on his hip in the sand

with a grunt.

Somebody laughed. Master Brand didn't.

"*Good!*" he roared. "Ugly as sin, Calder, but good! You're alive, aren't you? Being alive is the whole point! Again!"

Owen got up, spitting sand. Across the circle, Julian's face had gone very still.

Owen had his book open in his left hand. He had no idea what he was doing. He'd never fought anyone in his life except Jonah, when they were eight, over a plum, and Jonah had won by sitting on him. He watched Julian's hands, and his feet, and the smoke curling up off his knuckles, and he breathed. In for four. Out for eight.

"Everyone's still talking about the courtyard," said Julian quietly, as they circled. Too quietly for Master Brand to hear. "Did you know? They say you made me kneel."

"I didn't make you do anything."

"*They say you made me kneel.*" Julian's voice cracked, just a little, on the last word. "In front of the whole school. My father heard about it last night. He telephoned. Do you know what he said to me?" His face twisted. "He asked me what a *Vance* was doing on his knees in front of a *dock rat*."

"Julian..."

"*Don't say my name.*"

And he threw the fire.

It wasn't a sparring throw. It wasn't a touch. It was everything he had: a roaring torrent of white-hot flame, pure and blinding, the same fire that had turned the Weighing Stone white. It came across the sand straight at Owen's chest, and the air around it rippled and screamed, and somewhere Master Brand was bellowing "*VANCE!*" and somewhere else someone was screaming, and there was no time to lighten anything, no time to breathe, no time to do anything at all...

Except open his hand.

He didn't decide to. It just happened. His right hand came up, palm out, crescent out, the way you'd throw up your hand to stop a ball hitting you in the face. And the word came up out of the second page of his book and out of his mouth on its own:

"Hunger."

The fire went in.

It didn't hit him. It didn't burn him. It poured into the crescent on his palm like water pouring down a drain, all of it, the whole white roaring torrent, and it kept pouring, and pouring, and it didn't stop until the last flicker of it had gone. Then the air rippled once more, and cleared.

The armory went dark.

Not completely. But every lamp along the walls had gone out at the same moment, their flames sucked sideways and down into Owen's hand along with Julian's fire, and the whole long room was suddenly dim and cold, lit only by the grey afternoon light coming through the high windows.

Owen stood on the sand with his hand still up.

He could feel it. The fire. It was *inside* him. Not burning. Sitting. A hot, bright weight in the middle of his chest, like a coal from Pop's boilers that he'd swallowed whole, and he could feel it there, humming, waiting, *his*. He could feel that if he wanted to, if he just opened his hand again and *let go*, it would come back out of him. All of it. White and roaring and twice as hot.

Whatever you take in, said the second page of his book, *you keep*.

And at the bottom of him, low and warm and utterly satisfied, like someone sinking into a hot bath after a long day, Arcanula sighed.

Oh, she breathed. *Oh, that was delicious*.

Julian Vance was on his knees on the sand.

Nobody had pushed him. He'd just gone down. His hands were empty and shaking, and there was no smoke coming off them now, and his face, in the grey light, was the colour of paper. He was staring at Owen's raised hand. He was staring at the crescent on it.

"What *are* you?" he whispered.

Nobody else in the armory said a word. Master Brand was standing at the edge of the sand with his mouth open. The other students were pressed back against the weapon racks. Somewhere at the back, a girl had started to cry.

Owen lowered his hand.

He could still feel the fire in his chest. He could still feel Arcanula, purring. And he could feel, right at the very back of his mind, a thought that wasn't his, sweet and patient: *Give it back to him. Go on. He threw it at you. He'd have burned your face off. Give it back.*

He closed his hand into a fist.

"Yield," he said.

The word came out hoarse. Master Brand blinked at him.

"What?"

"I yield." Owen turned around and walked off the sand. "He wins. Point to Vance."

He didn't look back. He walked out of the armory into the grey afternoon with his fist clenched so tight that his nails cut into his palm, and the fire sat in his chest like a stone, and Arcanula laughed softly at the back of his mind all the way across the courtyard.

You're no fun, she said fondly. But you're learning.

He went to the washroom in the east dormitory, because it was the only place he could think of where nobody would be, and he locked himself in the end stall and sat on the closed lid with his head in his hands.

The fire was still there. It wasn't going anywhere. He could feel the exact shape of it in his chest, hot and bright and roughly the size of a fist, and when he breathed in, it flared, and when he breathed out, it dimmed, like a coal under a bellows. He breathed out for eight. Then for ten. It dimmed, but it didn't go out.

After a while he went to the basin and splashed cold water on his face, and when he looked up at the little square mirror, he saw that the gas lamp on the wall beside it had bent.

Its flame wasn't pointing up anymore. It was leaning sideways, out of its glass, toward him. Straining toward him, thin and blue, the way a plant in a cellar strains toward the one crack of light. When he took a step to the left, it followed. When he took a step to the right, it followed.

It knows where the rest of it went, said Arcanula, amused. Fire's like that. It always wants to go home.

Owen turned the lamp off at the tap, and stood in the dark washroom, breathing, until his hands stopped shaking.

* * *

Jonah found him on the roof again, just after sunset.

He came up through the trapdoor with his hair sticking up and his storm-grey coat buttoned wrong, and he had something in each fist. He sat down on the tar paper next to Owen, with his long legs stuck out over the edge of the roof, and held out one hand.

It was a plum.

Owen looked at it.

"Where'd you get that?"

"Kitchens." Jonah shrugged. "They've got a whole barrel. Nobody was watching it. Old habits." He was still holding it out. "Go on. It's not poisoned. I'm Thunder, not whatever the poison one is."

Owen took the plum.

They sat and ate them in silence, looking out over the city as the lamps came on, street by street, down the hill to the harbor. When they'd finished, Jonah leaned forward and spat his stone off the edge of the roof, into the dark. After a moment, Owen did the same. They listened. Somewhere far below, very faintly, there was a *tick* as one of them hit the courtyard gravel.

"Mine went farther," said Jonah.

"It did not."

"It absolutely did. Mine hit the fountain. I heard it splash."

"You didn't hear anything."

"I heard it with my *heart*, Owen." Jonah grinned. "Anyway, I've got a proud history with plums. Remember Mrs. Abernathy's tree? When we were eight?"

"You sat on me."

"I *won*. Fair and square. You said the big one was yours, and I said it was mine, and then I sat on you until you agreed it was mine." Jonah looked enormously pleased with himself. "Best fight I ever had. Undefeated."

"You weighed twice what I did."

"That's called *strategy*." Jonah leaned back on his elbows. "And then Mrs. Abernathy came out with a broom and chased us both all the way down

Cable Street, and you fell in the gutter, and your mom made us both go and say sorry, and Mrs. Abernathy gave us the plums anyway." He was smiling at the sky. "That was a good day."

"Yeah," said Owen. It had been. He'd forgotten. He hadn't let himself remember much about Cable Street, the last few months. It had been easier to keep it all shut up in a box, the way you'd keep a burn out of the air. "That was a good day."

Then Jonah's smile faded, and he was quiet for a while. When he spoke again, he didn't look at Owen. He looked out at the harbor.

"I heard about the armory," he said.

Owen didn't say anything.

"Everyone's heard about the armory. They're saying you ate Julian Vance's fire. They're saying the lamps went out." Jonah picked at the tar paper with his thumbnail. "They're saying a lot of stuff. Some of it's pretty bad."

"Some of it's probably true."

Jonah was quiet again. Then he said, "I'm not gonna ask."

Owen looked at him.

"I'm not," said Jonah. "I want to. I really, really want to. It's killing me, Owen. But I figure if you could tell me, you would've told me, and you haven't, so you can't. So I'm not gonna ask." He turned and looked at Owen properly for the first time. "I just... I'm gonna say one thing, and then I'll shut up, alright?"

"Alright."

"Don't disappear on me again." Jonah's voice was very steady. "That's all. After Talia left, you just... went. You stopped coming up on the roof. You stopped answering the door. I knocked for three months, Owen. *Three months*. And then I figured you didn't want me knocking. So I stopped." He swallowed. "And I've felt rotten about it every single day since. So whatever this is, whatever's going on with you and the gas leak and the fire and the thing with your hand, I don't need to know what it is. I just need you to not disappear. Okay?"

Owen looked at his old friend, sitting on the edge of the roof with his hair on end and his coat buttoned wrong and a plum stain on his chin, and

something in his throat went very tight.

“Okay,” he said.

“Okay.” Jonah let out a long breath, and grinned. “Good. Great. That was really awkward. I’m glad it’s over.” He stood up and brushed tar off his coat. “Same time tomorrow? I’ll bring more plums. I’m gonna rob that barrel blind.”

“Same time tomorrow,” said Owen.

Jonah climbed down through the trapdoor. Owen heard him on the ladder, humming. Then the humming stopped, and there was a pause, and then Jonah’s voice, a bit awkward: “Oh. Hi. Um. He’s... he’s up there.”

And then someone else was climbing up the ladder.

* * *

It was Talia.

She came up through the trapdoor slowly, and she didn’t come all the way. She stopped with her head and shoulders out on the roof and her hands gripping the edges of the hatch, and she didn’t look at him. She was looking down, at the tar paper, very carefully. Her eyes were fixed on a spot about a yard in front of his boots.

“Don’t,” said Owen.

“I’m not going to look at you,” said Talia. Her voice was shaking. “I’m not. I’m going to keep my eyes on the roof, and I’m not going to look up, and I’m going to say one thing. Just one. And then I’ll go. Please.”

Owen didn’t say anything. He didn’t say yes. He didn’t say no.

She took that as an answer.

“That night,” she said, to the tar paper. “On the landing. With the cake.” Her hands were white on the edges of the hatch. “I didn’t shut the door because I wanted to. I’ve never wanted anything *less* in my whole life. I shut it because they told me it was the only way to keep you safe, and I believed them, and I...” She stopped. Breathed. “And I think I might have been wrong. About some of it. And I think it might be too late now. But I needed you to know that it was never because I didn’t...”

She stopped again.

And then, before she could stop herself, she looked up.

Owen watched it happen. He watched her eyes lift from the tar paper to his face, and then past his face, up and to the left, to the place just over his shoulder. And he watched her whole face go still and white and horrified, exactly the way it had in the classroom, exactly the way it had the night before.

Only this time she didn't scream. She didn't flinch. She just stared, very quietly, at whatever was standing behind him.

"It's different," she whispered.

"What?"

"Last night it was... big. Dark. It had horns, and it was so *big*." Her voice was barely a breath. "This one's a woman. She's got her arms around you. Her chin's on your shoulder. And she's..." Talia's lips were trembling. "She's *smiling* at me, Owen. She's got so many teeth."

Owen didn't turn around. He didn't need to. He could feel it: the cold, fond weight of something resting against his back, and a sharp chin on his shoulder, and a voice murmuring into his ear so softly that only he could hear it.

Tell her to run along, darling, said Arcanula. *Tell her the lamp is making my eyes hurt.*

"Go, Talia," Owen said.

She looked at him. Just at him, for one second. Her golden eyes were wet.

"Keep me safe from what?" Owen said. "You said they told you it would keep me safe. Safe from *what*?"

But she was already gone, down through the trapdoor, and he heard her boots on the ladder, fast, and then running down the corridor below, and then nothing.

* * *

When he came down off the roof, room nine was empty. Julian's things were gone. The bed by the window had been stripped to the mattress, and the wardrobe door hung open on nothing, and there was a note on the desk in beautiful handwriting that said only: *Transferred to the west dormitory at my father's request. Do not attempt to contact me.* It wasn't signed.

Owen sat down on his own bed.

He could still feel the fire in his chest. It hadn't faded. It sat there, hot and bright and patient, like a coal at the bottom of a stove that just needed one breath of air.

His book lay beside him. He hadn't opened it since the armory. He opened it now.

The first page: **Gravity.** *Lighten. Press. Pull.*

The second page: **Hunger.** *Whatever you take in, you keep.*

And a third page. Brand new. The ink still wet.

Feast.

Whatever you keep, you become.

He read it three times. He didn't understand it. And then, slowly, he did, and he sat very still on the bed with the book open on his knees and the fire burning in his chest, and he thought about the white flame, *Julian's* flame, that was sitting inside him right now. He thought about what it would mean to *become* it. To keep it. To make it his.

To open his hand, one day, and have it come out *his*.

And then he thought about what else a person could take in, and keep, if they were hungry enough.

He shut the book.

Don't look so worried, said Arcanula, from somewhere just behind his ear. Her voice was lazy and warm and very full. *It's only the third course. There's so much more to come.* A pause, and then, softer, almost shy: *And soon, darling, very soon now, it'll be my turn to go for a walk. You promised. Remember?*

"I remember," said Owen, to the empty room.

Good boy, she murmured, and went quiet.

He turned out the lamp and lay down on his back in the dark, with his right hand closed tight over the crescent, and the fire in his chest, and the book on the floor beside the bed, and he breathed. In for four. Out for eight. In for four. Out for eight.

Outside, the clock tower struck midnight.

On the eleventh stroke, the air in the middle of room nine *split open*.

* * *

It made no sound. That was the worst part. It just happened: a thin, bright line appeared in the empty air above Julian's stripped mattress, as if someone had drawn it there with a knife. It was perfectly straight and perfectly thin and as long as a door is tall. And then it *opened*, the two sides of it peeling back like the edges of a torn page, and through it Owen could see somewhere else.

Somewhere that wasn't room nine. Somewhere cold, and dark, and blue, with snow falling in it, and a sound like wind moving over a long way of nothing at all.

He couldn't move. He lay flat on his bed with his heart slamming and stared at the tear in the air.

A hand came through it.

It was a pale hand, slim, with long fingers, and a ring on every one of them. Silver rings, gold rings, rings with stones in them, rings of plain black iron, crowded so thick on each finger that they clinked together as the hand moved. It reached into the room, slowly, and it turned over, palm up, as if feeling the air for rain.

Then it stopped. As if it had felt something.

As if it had felt *him*.

"Found you," said a voice, from the other side of the tear.

It was a young voice. A girl's voice, maybe, or a boy's; it was hard to tell. It sounded pleased. It sounded like someone who had been looking for a coin down the back of a very large sofa for a very long time, and had just, finally, touched the edge of it with their fingertips.

"Gravity," said the voice, and laughed. *"Oh, the last one. The very last one. They hid you so nicely."*

The ringed fingers curled, slowly, into a fist.

"See you soon," said the voice.

And the hand drew back through the tear, and the tear sealed itself up like a healing cut, and room nine was dark and empty and silent again, as if nothing had ever been there at all.

Owen lay on his bed and didn't breathe.

Deep inside him, under the fire, under the hunger, he felt Arcanula come fully awake. He felt her rise up, slow and huge and cold, to her full

height inside his chest. He felt her hair stop drifting. He felt every one of her teeth.

Space, she hissed. *Greedy little thing. Karvesh's pet.*

And then, softer, in a voice he had never heard her use before, a voice that was almost like a promise:

Oh, darling. Dinner's coming to us.